Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 24 · DAYS 837-865

Faith Lived Out: General Epistles

James, 1-2 Peter, 1-3 John, Jude

What does genuine faith look like in real life? Holiness, love, suffering, perseverance.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"We love because he first loved us."

1 JOHN 4:19

Speech, integrity, and the cornerstone (12, 15, 24, 34, 118:1-18, 31:1-8) beside the General Epistles.

UNIT 24

In this unit

WEEK 120

837	James 1:1-27	*Reading*
838	James 2:1-26	*Reading*
839	James 2:14-26; Hebrews 11:1-6	*Doctrine*
840	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 121

841	James 3:1-4:17	*Reading*
842	James 5:1-20	*Reading*
843	Psalm 12	*Psalm*
844	Psalm 15	*Psalm*
845	Psalm 24	*Psalm*
846	1 Peter 1:1-2:12	*Reading*
847	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 122

848	1 Peter 2:13-3:22	*Reading*
849	1 Peter 4:1-5:14	*Reading*
850	2 Peter 1:1-21	*Reading*
851	2 Peter 1:16-21; 2 Peter 3:15-16	*Doctrine*
852	2 Peter 2:1-3:18	*Reading*
853	Psalm 34	*Psalm*
854	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 123

855	Psalm 118:1-18	*Psalm*
856	Psalm 31:1-8	*Psalm*
857	1 John 1:1-2:29	*Reading*
858	1 John 3:1-24	*Reading*

859	1 John 4:1-5:21	*Reading*
860	John 10:27-30; Romans 8:31-39; 1 John 5:11-13	*Doctrine*
861	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 124

862	2 John 1:1-13	*Reading*
863	3 John 1:1-14	*Reading*
864	Jude 1:1-25	*Reading*
865	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 837 · WEEK 120

James 1:1-27

Trials; temptation; hearing and doing

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 27 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 1:1-27. James writes to Jewish Christians scattered abroad, and the letter reads like a collection of wisdom sayings. Notice how trials, temptation, and the word of God are tied together, and how often James moves from hearing to doing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author is James, the brother of Jesus, who became the leader of the church in Jerusalem (Acts 15; Galatians 1:19). He did not believe in Jesus during the earthly ministry (John 7:5), but the risen Lord appeared to him (1 Corinthians 15:7). This may be the earliest New Testament letter, written to Jewish believers scattered by persecution. It reads like the Sermon on the Mount applied to daily life. James begins by calling himself a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, a humble title for the Lord's own brother.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Count it all joy, my brothers, when you meet trials of various kinds" (v. 2).
2. "For you know that the testing of your faith produces steadfastness" (v. 3).
3. "If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask God, who gives generously to all without reproach, and it will be given him" (v. 5).
4. "Blessed is the man who remains steadfast under trial, for when he has stood the test he will receive the crown of life" (v. 12).
5. "But each person is tempted when he is lured and enticed by his own desire" (v. 14).
6. "Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights" (v. 17).

7. “But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves” (v. 22).

8. “Religion that is pure and undefiled before God the Father is this: to visit orphans and widows in their affliction, and to keep oneself unstained from the world” (v. 27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James opens with a surprising command: “Count it all joy, my brothers, when you meet trials of various kinds.” He does not say to enjoy suffering but to consider it joy, because “the testing of your faith produces steadfastness. And let steadfastness have its full effect, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking in nothing.” Trials are the gym where faith grows strong. And when we lack wisdom to understand them, we are to ask God, who “gives generously to all without reproach.” God does not scold us for asking. But we must ask in faith, with no doubting, for the double-minded person is “like a wave of the sea that is driven and tossed by the wind.” He is unstable in all his ways.

The poor brother is told to boast in his exaltation, and the rich in his humiliation, because the rich will pass away like a flower in the grass. The verdict is given in verse 12: “Blessed is the man who remains steadfast under trial, for when he has stood the test he will receive the crown of life, which God has promised to those who love him.” The reward is life itself.

Then James separates trials from temptation. A trial tests us, and God uses it for good. But temptation is something else, and God never tempts anyone. “But each person is tempted when he is lured and enticed by his own desire. Then desire when it has conceived gives birth to sin, and sin when it is fully grown brings forth death.” James traces the path with vivid pictures: desire is the bait, sin is the offspring, and death is the end. We cannot blame God or circumstances. On the contrary, “every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights with whom there is no variation or shadow due to change.” The Father gives only good, and he does not change. Of his own will he brought us forth by the word of truth, that we should be a kind of firstfruits of his creatures.

The rest of the chapter is about the word. “Let every person be quick to hear, slow to speak, slow to anger; for the anger of man does not produce the righteousness of God.” We are to put away filthiness and “receive with meekness the implanted word, which is able to save your souls.” But the word must be obeyed: “Be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves.” The one who hears and does not do is like a man who looks at his face in a mirror and goes away, immediately forgetting what he was like. But the one who looks into “the perfect law, the law of liberty,” and perseveres, “being no hearer who forgets but a doer who acts, he will be blessed in his doing.” The chapter ends with three tests of real religion: a controlled tongue, care for orphans and widows, and keeping oneself unstained from the world.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 5:10-12 and Romans 5:3-5 also connect suffering to joy and hope. 1 Peter 1:6-7 speaks of faith tested by fire. 1 Kings 3:5-14 shows Solomon asking God for wisdom. Proverbs 2:1-6 says the LORD gives wisdom. Matthew 7:7-11 teaches us to ask a generous Father. Matthew 7:24-27 speaks of hearing and doing. Revelation 2:10 promises the crown of life. Deuteronomy 10:18 and Isaiah 1:17 command care for orphans and widows. Luke 8:21 says Jesus' family are those who hear and do the word.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a trial you are in now. Say out loud: God is using this to produce steadfastness. Ask him for wisdom for it, and believe he gives generously.

Look at the path in verses 14 and 15. What desire is luring you? Name it, and flee it before it grows.

Pick one thing you read in the Bible this week and do it today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for every good gift from him.
- Ask him to teach you to count trials as joy, and ask for wisdom.
- Ask him to make you a doer of the word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."

JAMES 1:22

DAY 838 · WEEK 120

James 2:1-26

Partiality; faith without works is dead

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 2:1-26. This chapter has two parts: a warning against favoring the rich, and a famous argument that faith without works is dead. As you read, ask what kind of faith James is rejecting, and keep the whole chapter in view.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In the first-century world, wealth bought honor, and the poor were treated as nobodies. James knew congregations where a rich man in fine clothing would be given a seat of honor while a poor man was told to stand or sit on the floor. This betrayed the gospel. The second half of the chapter takes on a different danger, a faith that is claimed but never lived. The question is not whether faith or works saves, but what kind of faith is real.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “My brothers, show no partiality as you hold the faith in our Lord Jesus Christ, the Lord of glory” (v. 1).
2. “Has not God chosen those who are poor in the world to be rich in faith and heirs of the kingdom?” (v. 5).
3. “You shall love your neighbor as yourself” (v. 8).
4. “Mercy triumphs over judgment” (v. 13).
5. “What good is it, my brothers, if someone says he has faith but does not have works? Can that faith save him?” (v. 14).
6. “So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead” (v. 17).
7. “Even the demons believe” (v. 19).

8 “For as the body apart from the spirit is dead, so also faith apart from works is dead” (v. 26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James begins with a clear principle: “show no partiality as you hold the faith in our Lord Jesus Christ, the Lord of glory.” The church is where the world’s rankings are overturned. If you honor the rich man and dishonor the poor, you have “become judges with evil thoughts.” God has chosen the poor to be “rich in faith and heirs of the kingdom,” and yet they were the ones being insulted, while the rich were the ones oppressing the church and blaspheming the name. The “royal law” is to love your neighbor as yourself. To show partiality is to be “convicted by the law as transgressors,” for whoever keeps the whole law but fails in one point has become accountable for all of it. We will be judged by “the law of liberty,” so speak and act accordingly. “For judgment is without mercy to one who has shown no mercy. Mercy triumphs over judgment.”

The second half asks a pointed question: “What good is it, my brothers, if someone says he has faith but does not have works? Can that faith save him?” The Greek makes clear that the answer is no: that kind of faith cannot save. James gives an example. If a brother or sister is poorly clothed and lacking daily food, and you say, “Go in peace, be warmed and filled,” without giving what is needed, what good is that? “So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead.” It is not merely weak; it is dead. Next James imagines an objector who says that one has faith and another has works. James replies, “Show me your faith apart from your works, and I will show you my faith by my works.” Then he points out that even the demons believe that God is one, and shudder. Mere agreement with a fact is not saving faith.

Two examples follow. Abraham was “justified by works when he offered up his son Isaac on the altar.” James says that “faith was active along with his works, and faith was completed by his works; and the Scripture was fulfilled that says, Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness.” Rahab the prostitute was also “justified by works when she received the messengers and sent them out by another way.” James concludes: “You see that a person is justified by works and not by faith alone. For as the body apart from the spirit is dead, so also faith apart from works is dead.”

How does this fit with Paul, who says in Romans 4 that Abraham was justified by faith apart from works? Most Reformed and evangelical interpreters answer that Paul and James are fighting different enemies. Paul argues against those who say works earn salvation. James argues against those who say that a profession without obedience is enough. Paul uses “justify” to mean being declared righteous before God, while James uses it to mean being

shown to be righteous, vindicated by what one does. Paul says we are saved by faith alone; James says the faith that saves is never alone. Both agree that real faith produces obedience. We explore this on Day 839.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 19:18 is the source of the royal law, and Jesus affirmed it in Matthew 22:39. Deuteronomy 1:17 forbids partiality in judgment. 1 Corinthians 1:26-29 says God chose the weak and low. Matthew 25:31-46 ties judgment to mercy shown to the needy. 1 John 3:17-18 echoes James on love in deed. Genesis 15:6 and Romans 4:1-5 are the texts about Abraham's faith. Genesis 22 is the offering of Isaac. Joshua 2 and Hebrews 11:31 are about Rahab. Ephesians 2:8-10 joins grace and good works.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself whom you tend to favor and whom you tend to overlook, whether at church, at work, or among your neighbors. Treat one overlooked person with real honor this week.

Meet a concrete need today, for someone near you, with more than good wishes.

Memorize verse 13 as a reminder: mercy triumphs over judgment.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have favored the wealthy or the powerful.
- Ask God to show you the faith that works through love.
- Thank him that he chose the poor to be rich in faith.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."

JAMES 1:22

DAY 839 · WEEK 120

James 2:14-26; Hebrews 11:1-6

What distinguishes saving faith

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Doctrine · 19 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 2:14-26 and Hebrews 11:1-6. Today is a doctrinal pause on saving faith. Notice what James says dead faith lacks and what Hebrews says living faith does.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

What is saving faith? The question matters for every Christian. Paul says we are justified by faith alone, apart from works of the law. James says a person is justified by works and not by faith alone. Hebrews gives a portrait of faith in action. Taken together, the New Testament teaches that faith is the only way we receive Christ, and that the faith which receives him always leads to a changed life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will show you my faith by my works" (James 2:18).
2. "Even the demons believe" (James 2:19).
3. "You see that faith was active along with his works, and faith was completed by his works" (James 2:22).
4. "Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness" (James 2:23).
5. "Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen" (Hebrews 11:1).
6. "By faith Abel offered to God a more acceptable sacrifice than Cain" (Hebrews 11:4).
7. "By faith Enoch was taken up so that he should not see death" (Hebrews 11:5).
8. "And without faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever would draw near to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him" (Hebrews 11:6).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Saving faith is the God-given trust by which a sinner rests on Christ alone for salvation. It is a gift of God (Ephesians 2:8-9) and the instrument, not the ground, by which we are justified. Our faith does not earn anything; it receives what Christ has earned.

The older theologians distinguished three elements. Knowledge (notitia): we must know the facts of the gospel, who Jesus is and what he has done. Assent (assensus): we must agree that these facts are true. Trust (fiducia): we must personally rest on Christ and entrust ourselves to him. The demons have the first two, and even tremble, but they do not have the third. Saving faith is not just believing that, but believing in: relying on a person.

Faith alone, but never alone. This phrase summarizes the Reformation teaching. We are justified by faith alone, not by faith plus works. But the faith that justifies is never by itself; it always produces works, because the Spirit who gives faith also gives new life. Works are the fruit and evidence of faith, not the root of salvation. That is why Paul can say that a person is counted righteous apart from works of the law (Romans 3:28; 4:5), and also that the only thing that counts is "faith working through love" (Galatians 5:6).

How do Paul and James fit together? Several observations help. First, they address different opponents: Paul faces legalists who rely on works of the law, and James faces people who claim faith but live in disobedience. Second, they use the word "justify" somewhat differently: for Paul, it is God's declaration that a sinner is righteous; for James, in this context, it is the vindication of a claim to faith by the evidence of works (compare Matthew 11:19). Third, they mean different things by "faith": for Paul, it is trusting in Christ; for James, the faith in view is a bare profession. Both use Abraham to make their point, and both quote Genesis 15:6.

Other traditions explain the relationship differently. The Roman Catholic Church teaches that justification includes an inward renewal and is advanced by cooperation with grace through works of love. Some Arminian traditions emphasize that faith must continue for salvation to continue. Evangelicals who hold to progressive covenantalism and Reformed convictions teach that justification is a once-for-all declaration received by faith alone, which is inseparable from sanctification. We should read James as correcting a dead orthodoxy, not as overturning Paul.

Hebrews 11 shows what living faith looks like. It is "the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen." Abel, Enoch, and Noah all acted on what God said, even when they could not see the result. "Without faith it is impossible to please him." Faith is not wishful thinking; it is confident trust in the God who speaks and promises.

STEP 4

Interpretation

James presents a test: can you show your faith? “I will show you my faith by my works.” He is not saying works replace faith. He is saying that invisible faith becomes visible by what it does. Think of a tree: you know what kind it is by its fruit. Faith in a good God leads to love for neighbor, in the way that trust in a doctor leads to following his prescription.

His example is Abraham, who offered Isaac. Abraham had been counted righteous in Genesis 15, many years earlier, when he simply believed God. In Genesis 22, his obedience demonstrated that his faith was real. “Faith was active along with his works, and faith was completed by his works.” Completed here means brought to its intended end, its full expression, not that something was lacking in the faith. The “fulfilled” Scripture is Genesis 15:6: what God declared about Abraham was shown to be true.

Hebrews 11 gives the same picture from another angle. Faith believes that God exists and that he rewards those who seek him. Abel offered a better sacrifice because he trusted God; Enoch walked with God and was taken; Noah built an ark. Each acted on a word from God. In every case, faith moves people to act. So the question for us is not only “Do I believe?” but “Whom do I trust, and what does my life show?”

The comfort here is that faith is not a work we produce to earn God’s favor. A small faith in a great Savior saves. The Lord can work with a mustard seed. But the faith that saves does not stay inactive.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 2:8-10 joins grace, faith, and works. Romans 3:28, 4:1-5, and Galatians 2:16 give Paul’s statements on justification by faith. Galatians 5:6 speaks of faith working through love. Genesis 15:6 and 22:1-19 are the two scenes from Abraham’s life. Matthew 7:16-20 says we know a tree by its fruit. Matthew 17:20 says faith like a mustard seed is enough. John 6:28-29 says the work of God is to believe in the one he sent. Titus 2:11-14 and 3:8 tie grace to good works. Mark 9:24 is the prayer, “I believe; help my unbelief!”

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself the three questions: Do I know the gospel? Do I agree it is true? Have I put my whole trust in Christ to save me?

If you doubt your faith, look not for a perfect record but for a direction: are you growing in love for God and neighbor?

Choose one act of obedience that expresses your trust in God today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the gift of faith.
- Tell him that you trust in Christ alone, not in your works.
- Ask him to let that faith show in what you do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."

JAMES 1:22

DAY 840 · WEEK 120

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read James 1:22 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves."

JAMES 1:22

REST

Meditation

This verse is simple and uncomfortable. It is possible to hear the word every week, to read the Bible daily, to take notes at a sermon, and still be deceived about ourselves. The danger James describes is not ignorance but self-deception: thinking that because we have heard, we have obeyed.

Doing the word does not mean earning salvation. It means that the word we receive changes the way we live. The man who looks in the mirror and walks away forgetting what he saw has missed the point of the mirror. Scripture shows us who we are and who we are becoming in Christ, and then it calls us to act.

Ask the Spirit today: what have I heard that I have not yet done? Then take the first small step.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the General Epistles with James. In chapter 1, trials were called joy because they produce steadfastness, we were told to ask God for wisdom, we saw how desire gives birth to sin, and we were charged to be doers of the word and not hearers only. In chapter 2, James called the church to show no partiality, to love the neighbor as the royal law requires, and to prove faith by works. On Day 839 we paused to consider saving faith: knowing, agreeing, and trusting, faith alone but never alone, and how Paul and James fit together alongside the portrait of faith in Hebrews 11.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

James says to count trials as joy because they produce steadfastness. What trial are you in or near right now, and how might God be using it to grow your faith?

James calls us to be doers of the word. What is one thing you have heard from Scripture or a sermon recently that you have not yet put into practice? What is a first step?

Our works do not earn our salvation, because Christ has already done everything needed. How does it change your obedience to know that you are already accepted because of him?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for rest and for his word.

Ask him to make you a doer and not only a hearer.

Ask him to keep you from deceiving yourself.

DAY 841 · WEEK 121

James 3:1-4:17

The tongue; worldliness; humility before God

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 35 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 3:1-4:17. Two themes run through these chapters: the power of the tongue and the war between friendship with the world and humility before God. Notice the contrast between wisdom from below and wisdom from above.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

James is writing to churches where speech was causing division. Teachers were quick to claim authority, and quarrels were breaking out among believers. James traces conflict to its source in the heart and calls the church to humble repentance. In Jewish wisdom writing, the tongue and the heart were closely tied, and James follows this tradition, with echoes of Proverbs and the teaching of Jesus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “How great a forest is set ablaze by such a small fire!” (3:5).
2. “No human being can tame the tongue” (3:8).
3. “But the wisdom from above is first pure, then peaceable, gentle, open to reason, full of mercy and good fruits, impartial and sincere” (3:17).
4. “What causes quarrels and what causes fights among you?” (4:1).
5. “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble” (4:6).
6. “Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you” (4:8).
7. “For you are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes” (4:14).
8. “So whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin” (4:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James begins with a warning for teachers: “Not many of you should become teachers, my brothers, for you know that we who teach will be judged with greater strictness. For we all stumble in many ways.” Anyone who does not stumble in what he says is a perfect man. Then come the pictures: a bit in a horse’s mouth, a rudder on a ship, a spark in a forest. The tongue is small but steers the whole body. “So also the tongue is a small member, yet it boasts of great things. How great a forest is set ablaze by such a small fire!” It is “a world of unrighteousness” and “set on fire by hell.” Every kind of creature has been tamed by mankind, “but no human being can tame the tongue. It is a restless evil, full of deadly poison.” Our greatest inconsistency is that “with it we bless our Lord and Father, and with it we curse people who are made in the likeness of God.” A spring does not pour out fresh and salt water. Only the Spirit can change the heart so that the mouth follows.

James then contrasts two kinds of wisdom. Bitter jealousy and selfish ambition are “earthly, unspiritual, demonic,” and where they are found, there is disorder and every vile practice. “But the wisdom from above is first pure, then peaceable, gentle, open to reason, full of mercy and good fruits, impartial and sincere. And a harvest of righteousness is sown in peace by those who make peace.” This is a checklist for every conflict.

In chapter 4, James asks where conflict comes from: “What causes quarrels and what causes fights among you? Is it not this, that your passions are at war within you?” We desire and do not have, so we murder (in heart); we covet and cannot obtain, so we fight. We do not have because we do not ask, or we ask wrongly, to spend it on our passions. He calls his readers “adulterous people,” echoing the prophets’ language of God’s people unfaithful to their covenant husband: “Whoever wishes to be a friend of the world makes himself an enemy of God.” But God gives more grace: “God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.”

The remedy is a series of commands: “Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you. Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you. Cleanse your hands, you sinners, and purify your hearts, you double-minded.” Grieve over sin, and “humble yourselves before the Lord, and he will exalt you.” Do not speak evil of one another, since it makes you a judge of the law instead of a doer. The chapter closes with a warning to the self-assured planner: “You do not know what tomorrow will bring. What is your life? For you are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes.” Instead, say, “If the Lord wills, we will live and do this or that.” And one summary sin: “Whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin.” Sins of omission count.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 18:21 says death and life are in the power of the tongue. Matthew 12:34-37 teaches that the mouth speaks from the heart's abundance. Ephesians 4:29 and Colossians 4:6 direct our speech. Genesis 1:26-27 is behind the "likeness of God." Hosea 2 and Jeremiah 3 use adultery as an image of unfaithfulness. Proverbs 3:34 is quoted in 4:6, and 1 Peter 5:5-9 echoes it. Matthew 5:9 blesses peacemakers. Proverbs 27:1 and Luke 12:16-21 warn about boasting about tomorrow. Psalm 39:5 and 90:5-6 describe life as a breath.

STEP 6

Application

Before you speak in a hard conversation today, run it through verse 3:17: is it pure, peaceable, gentle, open to reason, and merciful?

Name a quarrel and ask what desire is behind it (4:1-2). Confess it to God, and make the first move toward peace.

Practice saying "If the Lord wills" as you plan the week, and mean it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what your tongue has done.
- Ask him to change your heart because you cannot tame your tongue.
- Ask him to give you wisdom from above.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 842 · WEEK 121

James 5:1-20

The rich; patience; prayer; restoring the wanderer

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read James 5:1-20. James closes with a warning to the rich, a call to patience, and instruction on prayer and care for one another. Notice how often James points to the coming of the Lord.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Many of the first Christians were poor, and landowners sometimes withheld wages from day laborers. James speaks like an Old Testament prophet against such injustice. He then turns to the suffering believers and calls them to wait for the Lord's return with patience, like a farmer waiting for rain. The letter ends with a practical section on prayer, anointing the sick, and restoring those who wander.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Come now, you rich, weep and howl for the miseries that are coming upon you" (v. 1).
2. "Be patient, therefore, brothers, until the coming of the Lord" (v. 7).
3. "Behold, we consider those blessed who remained steadfast" (v. 11).
4. "Is anyone among you suffering? Let him pray" (v. 13).
5. "Let him call for the elders of the church, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord" (v. 14).
6. "The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working" (v. 16).
7. "Elijah was a man with a nature like ours, and he prayed fervently that it might not rain" (v. 17).

8 “Whoever brings back a sinner from his wandering will save his soul from death and will cover a multitude of sins” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James speaks to the wealthy who trust in riches: “Come now, you rich, weep and howl for the miseries that are coming upon you. Your riches have rotted and your garments are moth-eaten. Your gold and silver have corroded, and their corrosion will be evidence against you.” Their sin is hoarding in the last days, and especially withholding the wages of the laborers who mowed their fields. Those cries have “reached the ears of the Lord of hosts.” They have lived in luxury and self-indulgence, fattening their hearts “in a day of slaughter,” and have condemned and murdered the righteous person, who does not resist. James is not condemning wealth in itself but its misuse and the injustice by which it was gained.

Then he turns to the suffering: “Be patient, therefore, brothers, until the coming of the Lord.” The farmer waits for the precious fruit of the earth, being patient until it receives the early and the late rains. “You also, be patient. Establish your hearts, for the coming of the Lord is at hand.” Do not grumble against one another. The Judge is standing at the door. For examples, he points to the prophets and to Job: “You have heard of the steadfastness of Job, and you have seen the purpose of the Lord, how the Lord is compassionate and merciful.” Our suffering has a purpose, and the Lord’s character is compassion. He also warns against oaths: “Let your yes be yes and your no be no.” Be people whose word is reliable.

The final section is about prayer. “Is anyone among you suffering? Let him pray. Is anyone cheerful? Let him sing praise.” The church should pray in every circumstance. “Is anyone among you sick? Let him call for the elders of the church, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord. And the prayer of faith will save the one who is sick, and the Lord will raise him up. And if he has committed sins, he will be forgiven.” Christians differ on the meaning of the anointing: some take it as medicinal (oil was used as medicine), some as symbolic of setting apart for God, and some as a sacramental act. In every reading, the healing comes from the Lord, not the oil, and the emphasis is on prayer by the elders. Not every sick person is healed in this life, as Paul’s thorn and Timothy’s ailments show, but the Lord hears and may raise up.

“Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working.” Elijah is the example. He “was a man with a nature like ours,” yet when he prayed, the rain stopped for three and a half years, and when he prayed again, the heavens gave rain. We are as weak as Elijah, but we pray to the same God. The letter ends without a benediction, with a charge: if anyone wanders from the truth and someone brings him back, “let him know that whoever

brings back a sinner from his wandering will save his soul from death and will cover a multitude of sins." Caring for a wandering brother is among the most loving things a Christian can do.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 24:14-15 and Leviticus 19:13 forbid withholding wages. Isaiah 5:8-10 and Amos 5:11-12 are prophetic warnings against the rich. Matthew 6:19-21 and Luke 12:16-21 speak of treasure. Deuteronomy 11:14 mentions early and late rains. Job 42:10-17 shows the end of Job's story. Matthew 5:33-37 is Jesus' teaching on oaths. Mark 6:13 mentions anointing the sick. 1 Kings 17-18 is the Elijah account. Galatians 6:1 and Matthew 18:15 speak of restoring a brother. Proverbs 10:12 and 1 Peter 4:8 say love covers a multitude of sins.

STEP 6

Application

Be honest about how you use money. Ask whether you are being generous or hoarding, and whether you pay what you owe.

Pray for someone who is sick, and ask your pastor how your church cares for the sick.

Think of someone who has wandered from the faith. Pray for them, and reach out this week with love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from trusting in riches or using them unjustly.
- Ask him to give you patience.
- Pray for someone who has wandered, and ask what you might do.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

“Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you.”

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 843 · WEEK 121

Psalm 12

Save, O LORD, the tongue and its lying words

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 12. It is a short prayer of David about a world full of lies. Notice the contrast between the words of the wicked and the words of the LORD.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 12 is a psalm of David, "according to The Sheminith," possibly a musical direction. David prays in a time when truth seems to have vanished, when flattery and boasting fill the land and the poor are trampled. It fits our reading in James, where the tongue can be a fire or a source of blessing, and teaches what to do when the words around us cannot be trusted.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Save, O LORD, for the godly one is gone; for the faithful have vanished from among the children of man" (v. 1).
2. "Everyone utters lies to his neighbor; with flattering lips and a double heart they speak" (v. 2).
3. "May the LORD cut off all flattering lips" (v. 3).
4. "With our tongue we will prevail" (v. 4).
5. "Because the poor are plundered, because the needy groan, I will now arise" (v. 5).
6. "The words of the LORD are pure words, like silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven times" (v. 6).
7. "You, O LORD, will keep them; you will guard us from this generation forever" (v. 7).
8. "On every side the wicked prowl, as vileness is exalted among the children of man" (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a cry of alarm: “Save, O LORD, for the godly one is gone; for the faithful have vanished from among the children of man!” David feels that no honest person remains. The problem is speech: “Everyone utters lies to his neighbor; with flattering lips and a double heart they speak.” The phrase “a double heart” is literally “a heart and a heart”: saying one thing and meaning another. This is the same double-mindedness James warns about. David asks God to cut off flattering lips and the boastful tongue, those who say, “With our tongue we will prevail, our lips are with us; who is master over us?” They believe their words are their own and answer to no one.

Then the LORD speaks, and the psalm turns: “Because the poor are plundered, because the needy groan, I will now arise,” says the LORD; “I will place him in the safety for which he longs.” God hears the groaning of the needy and responds with a promise. Where human words are lies, his words can be trusted: “The words of the LORD are pure words, like silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven times.” Silver purified seven times has no impurity. We can rest our whole weight on what God says.

The psalm ends with confidence mixed with realism. “You, O LORD, will keep them; you will guard us from this generation forever.” The promise is of protection, not of an easy time: “On every side the wicked prowl, as vileness is exalted among the children of man.” The wicked still prowl, and shame is honored. But the word of the LORD stands. This is the experience of the church in every age. Evil seems to be flourishing, yet God’s words are pure, and God keeps his own. In Christ, the Word who is the truth (John 14:6), we find the final answer. The one who “committed no sin, neither was deceit found in his mouth” (1 Peter 2:22) is the faithful one in a world of liars.

STEP 5

Connection

James 3:1-12 speaks of the tongue. Psalm 5:9 and 55:21 describe flattering and deceitful speech. Psalm 119:140 and Proverbs 30:5 describe the purity of God’s word. Isaiah 3:14-15 speaks of the plundered poor. Exodus 3:7-8 shows God hearing the groaning of the oppressed. Isaiah 33:10 has a similar “now I will arise.” John 14:6 and 17:17 present Jesus and the word as truth. 1 Peter 2:22 speaks of Christ’s speech. Ephesians 4:25 commands truth-telling. Revelation 21:8 and 22:15 speak of the end of liars.

STEP 6

Application

Make yourself a person of single-hearted speech today: say what you mean, and refuse flattery.

When you feel that truth has vanished around you, turn to Scripture as pure silver and read a passage slowly.

Pray for the poor and needy in your community, and ask what the LORD may want you to do.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what lies and flattery you see.

Thank him that his words are pure.

Ask him to keep you from boasting and double speech.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 844 · WEEK 121

Psalm 15

Who shall sojourn on your holy hill?

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 15. This short psalm asks who may dwell with God and gives the answer in a list of ten character marks. Read it slowly, and notice that the list is about everyday integrity.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 15 is a psalm of David, probably used as an entrance liturgy when worshipers approached the sanctuary. A question is asked: who may be a guest in God's tent? The answer is a description of a person whose life matches their worship. James would call this a doer of the word. The psalm raises a question that only the gospel can answer: who is so blameless?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill?" (v. 1).
2. "He who walks blamelessly and does what is right" (v. 2).
3. "And speaks truth in his heart" (v. 2).
4. "Who does not slander with his tongue and does no evil to his friend" (v. 3).
5. "In whose eyes a vile person is despised, but who honors those who fear the LORD" (v. 4).
6. "Who swears to his own hurt and does not change" (v. 4).
7. "Who does not put out his money at interest" (v. 5).
8. "He who does these things shall never be moved" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a question about access: “O LORD, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill?” To sojourn means to stay as a guest, and the tent is the sanctuary where God meets his people. The question is not about earning a place but about the kind of person who belongs there. In the Old Testament, to be close to God’s holy presence is a great privilege and requires holiness.

The answer has three layers. First, general character: “He who walks blamelessly and does what is right and speaks truth in his heart.” Blamelessness means integrity, a life that is whole. Truth is spoken not only with the lips but in the heart; no gap exists between inner conviction and outer speech. Second, how he treats his neighbor: he “does not slander with his tongue and does no evil to his friend, nor takes up a reproach against his friend.” Gossip and slander are named along with outright harm. Third, how he deals with the world: he despises a vile person (does not admire the corrupt) and honors those who fear the LORD. He keeps his promise even when it costs him: “who swears to his own hurt and does not change.” His word is his bond. He does not exploit the needy by charging them interest (Exodus 22:25) and does not take bribes against the innocent.

“He who does these things shall never be moved.” This is the life the whole of Scripture calls for. But who can say that he fits this description? None of us. Here we see our need for Christ. He is the one who walked blamelessly, who spoke truth from the heart, who kept his word even to his own hurt, going to the cross. He alone ascended the hill of the LORD with clean hands. Those who are in him are welcomed into God’s presence, not because they match this psalm but because he does, and his righteousness is counted as theirs. And then, by the Spirit, he begins to form this character in us. The list in Psalm 15 is both a mirror and a goal.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 24:3-6 asks a similar question. Isaiah 33:14-16 and Micah 6:6-8 also describe who may dwell with God. Exodus 22:25 and Deuteronomy 23:19-20 forbid interest on loans to the poor. Exodus 23:8 forbids bribes. Matthew 5:33-37 teaches on oaths. Ephesians 4:25-32 tells believers to put away falsehood and slander. 1 Peter 2:22 says no deceit was found in Christ’s mouth. Hebrews 4:14-16 invites us to draw near through our high priest. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says we become the righteousness of God in him. James 1:26-27 and 3:1-12 also test religion by speech and conduct.

STEP 6

Application

Read the ten marks slowly and mark the two where you most need growth. Ask the Spirit for help.

Ask whether you have broken a promise that cost you. If you can still keep it, do so.

Thank Christ that you are welcomed into God's tent because of his righteousness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask who may dwell on God's hill, and tell him you cannot by your own righteousness.

Thank Jesus for walking blamelessly and speaking truth.

Ask him to make you truthful and faithful.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 845 · WEEK 121

Psalm 24

Pure heart, clean hands

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 24. This psalm moves from the creation to the clean-handed worshiper to the King of glory entering the gates. Read the second half as a call and response, with different voices asking and answering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 24 is a psalm of David, likely sung when the ark of the covenant was brought up to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6). It is a processional psalm with three parts: the LORD's ownership of the earth (vv. 1-2), the character of those who may approach him (vv. 3-6), and the entry of the King (vv. 7-10). It pairs naturally with Psalm 15 and with James's call to purity of heart. Christians have long read it as a picture of Christ's ascension.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell therein" (v. 1).
2. "Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place?" (v. 3).
3. "He who has clean hands and a pure heart" (v. 4).
4. "He will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation" (v. 5).
5. "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in" (v. 7).
6. "Who is this King of glory? The LORD, strong and mighty, the LORD, mighty in battle!" (v. 8).

7. “Who is this King of glory? The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory!” (v. 10).

8. “For he has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers” (v. 2).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with the biggest claim possible: “The earth is the LORD’s and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell therein, for he has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers.” Everything belongs to God, including us. Nothing in the world is outside his claim. So the question is: how can anyone come to the One who owns all things?

“Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart, who does not lift up his soul to what is false and does not swear deceitfully.” Clean hands refer to actions, and a pure heart refers to motives. This is the same standard as Psalm 15, and James echoes it when he calls for cleansing hands and purifying hearts (James 4:8). Such a person “will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation.” Even this righteousness is a gift from the God of his salvation. Such is “the generation of those who seek him, who seek the face of the God of Jacob.”

Then the procession arrives at the gates. A voice cries: “Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in!” A watchman replies: “Who is this King of glory?” And the answer comes: “The LORD, strong and mighty, the LORD, mighty in battle!” The call is repeated, and the answer enlarges: “The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory!” The psalm leaves us at the threshold with the King entering.

Christians have long seen in this the ascension of Christ. The only one with truly clean hands and a pure heart is Jesus. He ascended the hill, was received into the Father’s presence, and entered the gates in victory after conquering sin and death. And because he has entered as our forerunner, we can follow him. The King of glory is also the one who welcomes the humble to his side. The gates open for him, and through him they open for us.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 15 is the companion psalm. 1 Corinthians 10:26 quotes verse 1. 2 Samuel 6:12-15 describes the ark entering Jerusalem. Isaiah 6:1-5 shows a holy King and an unclean people. Matthew 5:8 blesses the pure in heart. James 4:8 calls for cleansing of hands and hearts. Ephesians 4:8-10 and Acts 1:9-11 describe the ascension. Hebrews 4:14, 6:19-20, and 9:24 speak of Christ entering heaven as forerunner. 1 Corinthians 15:57 gives thanks for victory. Revelation 5:11-13 shows the worship of the King.

STEP 6

Application

Say verse 1 over your day: the earth is the LORD's and everything in it, including my money, time, and work.

Ask the Lord to give you clean hands and a pure heart, and confess anything he shows you.

Open the gates of your heart to the King of glory, and welcome him in as Lord over one area where you have held back.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you cannot ascend by your own clean hands.

Thank Jesus who ascended for you.

Open the gates of your life to the King of glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 846 · WEEK 121

1 Peter 1:1-2:12

Living hope; the church as new Israel; holy living

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Peter 1:1-2:12. Peter writes to scattered Christians who suffer for their faith. Notice how he moves from the great things God has done (a living hope, a precious inheritance) to a call to holiness, and then to a new identity as God's people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The apostle Peter wrote this letter around AD 62 to 64, probably from Rome (called "Babylon" in 5:13), to believers in the northern provinces of Asia Minor. Most were Gentiles, though Peter speaks to them in language drawn from Israel. They were "elect exiles," strangers in a hostile culture, and they faced slander and growing persecution. Peter, who once denied his Lord, writes with the gentleness of a restored man to encourage them to hope.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead" (1:3).
2. "The tested genuineness of your faith" (1:7).
3. "You also be holy in all your conduct" (1:15).
4. "With the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot" (1:19).
5. "Since you have been born again, not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living and abiding word of God" (1:23).
6. "You yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood" (2:5).

7. “But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession” (2:9).

8. “Keep your conduct among the Gentiles honorable, so that when they speak against you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day of visitation” (2:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter greets his readers as “elect exiles of the Dispersion,” chosen according to the foreknowledge of God the Father, in the sanctification of the Spirit, for obedience to Jesus Christ and for sprinkling with his blood. The Trinity is present from the first verse. Then he bursts into praise: “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you, who by God’s power are being guarded through faith for a salvation ready to be revealed in the last time.” Our hope is alive because Christ is alive, our inheritance is kept safe, and we are kept safe for it.

In this they rejoice, though they now suffer various trials, “so that the tested genuineness of your faith, more precious than gold that perishes though it is tested by fire, may be found to result in praise and glory and honor at the revelation of Jesus Christ.” Though they have not seen Christ, they love him, and they rejoice with joy that is inexpressible and filled with glory. The prophets searched and inquired about this salvation; angels long to look into these things.

From this foundation, Peter calls for holiness. “Therefore, preparing your minds for action, and being sober-minded, set your hope fully on the grace that will be brought to you at the revelation of Jesus Christ.” Do not conform to the passions of your former ignorance, “but as he who called you is holy, you also be holy in all your conduct, since it is written, You shall be holy, for I am holy.” They were ransomed “not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot.” He was foreknown before the foundation of the world but made manifest in the last times for their sake. The new birth is by “the living and abiding word of God.” Love one another earnestly from a pure heart. “The grass withers, and the flower falls, but the word of the Lord remains forever.” That word is the good news that was preached.

Chapter 2 begins with putting away malice, deceit, hypocrisy, envy, and slander, and craving “pure spiritual milk, that by it you may grow up into salvation.” Christ is the living stone, rejected by men but chosen and precious in God’s sight. Believers, too, are “living stones”

being built up as a spiritual house, “to be a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ.” Peter applies Old Testament texts about the stone: to those who believe, he is precious; to those who do not, he is a stone of stumbling.

Then the great statement of identity: “But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession, that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light. Once you were not a people, but now you are God’s people; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy.” These phrases were used of Israel at Sinai (Exodus 19:5-6) and now belong to the church, made up of Jew and Gentile. This fits the progressive covenantal view that the church is the new covenant people of God, not a replacement but the fulfillment of Israel’s calling in Christ. The purpose is mission: to proclaim his excellencies. As “sojourners and exiles,” they are to abstain from the passions of the flesh and keep their conduct honorable, so that their good deeds may lead even their accusers to glorify God.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 1:3-14 is a similar burst of praise. John 3:3-8 and Titus 3:5 speak of new birth. Isaiah 40:6-8 is quoted in 1:24-25. Leviticus 11:44-45 and 19:2 are the source for “be holy.” Isaiah 53 stands behind the lamb. Exodus 19:5-6 is the origin of “kingdom of priests, a holy nation.” Hosea 1:6-10 and 2:23 are behind 2:10. Psalm 118:22 and Isaiah 28:16 are the stone texts. Revelation 1:6 and 5:10 speak of a kingdom and priests. Matthew 5:16 also speaks of good works that glorify the Father. Hebrews 11:13 calls believers strangers and exiles.

STEP 6

Application

Praise God for your living hope before you do anything else today. Read 1:3-5 aloud.

Think about the phrase “chosen race, royal priesthood, holy nation, people for his own possession.” How does it change how you see yourself?

Choose one way to live honorably before a neighbor or coworker who is critical of your faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless God for causing you to be born again to a living hope.

Thank him for keeping an inheritance for you.

Ask him to help you live as a stranger and exile who is holy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 121

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

DAY 847 · WEEK 121

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Peter 1:3-4 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you."

1 PETER 1:3-4

REST

Meditation

Peter begins with praise, not with instruction. Before he tells his readers what to do, he reminds them what God has done. Everything flows from mercy: "According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again." We did not earn it, and we did not start it.

The hope is "living" because it is tied to the resurrection of Jesus Christ. A dead Savior would give a dead hope. Because he lives, our hope is not wishful thinking but a confident expectation.

The inheritance has three descriptions: imperishable (it cannot decay), undefiled (it cannot be corrupted), unfading (it cannot lose its beauty). And it is kept in heaven for you. Nothing here is stored where thieves or time can reach it.

When your week was hard, which phrase did you need most? Say it back to God as a prayer of thanks.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read James 3 to 5 and the opening of 1 Peter. James showed us the tongue that no human can tame, the two kinds of wisdom, the source of quarrels in our desires, humility before God, the brevity of life, the warning to the rich, patience until the Lord comes, and prayer for the sick and for the wanderer. Three psalms offered further wisdom: Psalm 12 on lying lips and the pure words of the LORD, Psalm 15 on who may dwell in God's tent, and Psalm 24 on the clean hands that ascend the hill and the King of glory who enters the gates. In 1 Peter 1:1 to 2:12, we heard of a living hope, tested faith, a call to holiness, redemption by the precious blood of Christ, and our identity as a chosen race, royal priesthood, holy nation, and people for God's own possession.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

James says no human being can tame the tongue. Where has your speech been most difficult to control, and how can you ask God to change your heart so that your words follow?

Psalms 15 and 24 describe someone with clean hands and a pure heart. Since none of us fits this description, how does Christ's perfect righteousness change the way you approach God?

Peter calls believers "a people for his own possession" who were "once not a people." How does belonging to God's people shape the way you live as an exile in this world?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for rest and for the living hope in Jesus.

Ask him to guard your faith.

Rest in his keeping.

DAY 848 · WEEK 122

1 Peter 2:13-3:22

Submission; suffering for righteousness; Christ's example

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Peter 2:13-3:22. Peter applies the gospel to life under authority: citizens, servants, wives, husbands, and the whole church. Notice that Christ is the pattern in every relationship and that suffering for doing good is a calling.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Christians in Asia Minor were slandered as lawless, antisocial, and subversive. Peter does not tell them to withdraw from society. He tells them to live so well that the accusations fall flat. The "household codes" in this section (similar to those in Ephesians 5-6 and Colossians 3) were not new in the ancient world, but Peter grounds them in Christ's example. Many of the servants and wives he addresses were in difficult situations, and he points them to the Suffering Servant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Be subject for the Lord's sake to every human institution" (2:13).
2. "Honor everyone. Love the brotherhood. Fear God. Honor the emperor" (2:17).
3. "For to this you have been called, because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps" (2:21).
4. "He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness" (2:24).
5. "Do not repay evil for evil or reviling for reviling, but on the contrary, bless" (3:9).
6. "But in your hearts honor Christ the Lord as holy, always being prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you" (3:15).

7. “For it is better to suffer for doing good, if that should be God’s will, than for doing evil” (3:17).

8. “Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring us to God” (3:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter first addresses believers as citizens: “Be subject for the Lord’s sake to every human institution, whether it be to the emperor as supreme, or to governors.” Government exists to punish wrongdoing and praise those who do good. “Live as people who are free, not using your freedom as a cover-up for evil, but living as servants of God.” Then four short commands: “Honor everyone. Love the brotherhood. Fear God. Honor the emperor.” Honor goes to all, but fear belongs to God alone. This does not mean unlimited submission; when the state demands what God forbids, we must obey God (Acts 5:29).

Next he speaks to household servants: be subject to your masters with all respect, even to the unjust. Why? “For to this you have been called, because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps.” Then Peter describes the Suffering Servant in the words of Isaiah 53. “He committed no sin, neither was deceit found in his mouth. When he was reviled, he did not revile in return; when he suffered, he did not threaten, but continued entrusting himself to him who judges justly. He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed. For you were straying like sheep, but have now returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls.” The cross is both an example and an atonement: first Christ is our substitute, and only then our model. We cannot imitate what we have not received.

Chapter 3 turns to marriage. Wives are to be subject to their own husbands, so that even if some do not obey the word, “they may be won without a word by the conduct of their wives.” Their beauty is to be that of “the hidden person of the heart with the imperishable beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which in God’s sight is very precious.” Husbands are to live with their wives “in an understanding way, showing honor to the woman as the weaker vessel, since they are heirs with you of the grace of life, so that your prayers may not be hindered.” Husbands and wives are equal heirs. Christians differ on how to apply the language of submission: complementarians see a distinct role of loving headship and willing submission rooted in creation, while egalitarians stress mutual submission and see the instruction as addressing a cultural setting. All agree that Peter calls both to humble, honoring love, and that abuse is never permissible.

Then the whole church: “have unity of mind, sympathy, brotherly love, a tender heart, and a humble mind.” Return blessing for insult. Do not fear what they fear, “but in your hearts honor Christ the Lord as holy, always being prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you; yet do it with gentleness and respect.” Notice that the world asks about our hope when it sees us respond well to suffering. Keep a good conscience, “for it is better to suffer for doing good, if that should be God’s will, than for doing evil.”

The ground of it is Christ: “For Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring us to God, being put to death in the flesh but made alive in the spirit.” The next verses (3:19-22) are among the hardest in the New Testament. Who are the “spirits in prison” to whom Christ proclaimed? Some think the fallen angels of Genesis 6 (as in 1 Enoch), to whom the risen Christ announced his victory; some think the people of Noah’s day, to whom Christ preached through Noah by his Spirit; and some think Christ descended to the dead. Likewise, “Baptism, which corresponds to this, now saves you” has been taken in different ways: as the outward sign that points to the inward reality, as an appeal to God for a good conscience, or as a means of grace. All agree that it is Christ’s resurrection that saves, and that he is now at God’s right hand, with angels, authorities, and powers subject to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 13:1-7 speaks of governing authorities, and Acts 4:19 and 5:29 show the limit. Isaiah 53:4-12 is behind 2:22-25. Ephesians 5:22-33 and Colossians 3:18-4:1 are the parallel household codes. Genesis 6:1-4 and Jude 6 touch on the spirits in prison. Genesis 6-8 is the account of Noah. 1 Peter 4:6 mentions the gospel preached to the dead. Romans 6:3-4 and Colossians 2:11-12 speak of baptism. Matthew 5:38-48 teaches blessing enemies. Psalm 34:12-16 is quoted in 3:10-12. Hebrews 1:3 and Ephesians 1:20-22 say Christ is at the right hand.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a person in authority over you whom you find hard to respect. Ask how you can honor them as unto the Lord, and how you can pray for them.

Rehearse 3:15 so you are ready to explain your hope to someone who asks. Write out a two-minute answer.

If you are married, ask your spouse how you can show them honor this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for not reviling in return when he was reviled.

Thank him for bearing your sins.

Ask him to help you suffer well when you suffer for doing right.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 849 · WEEK 122

1 Peter 4:1-5:14

Suffering; elders; the roaring lion; grace is sufficient

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 45 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Peter 4:1-5:14. Peter concludes by speaking of how to live in the face of suffering, how to use your gifts, how elders should lead, and how to resist the devil. Notice the repeated mention of grace and glory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Persecution against Christians was growing. Peter reminds his readers not to be surprised, since suffering is the normal path for those who follow the crucified Lord. He then gives instruction for the community: serve one another, elders shepherd the flock, the young submit, and all clothe themselves with humility. Peter, who was called to feed Christ's sheep (John 21:15-17), writes now as a fellow elder.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Above all, keep loving one another earnestly, since love covers a multitude of sins" (4:8).
2. "As each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God's varied grace" (4:10).
3. "Beloved, do not be surprised at the fiery trial when it comes upon you to test you, as though something strange were happening to you" (4:12).
4. "But rejoice insofar as you share Christ's sufferings, that you may also rejoice and be glad when his glory is revealed" (4:13).
5. "Shepherd the flock of God that is among you, exercising oversight, not under compulsion, but willingly, as God would have you" (5:2).

6. “Casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you” (5:7).

7. “Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour” (5:8).

8. “And after you have suffered a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to his eternal glory in Christ, will himself restore, confirm, strengthen, and establish you” (5:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter begins with a call to arm ourselves with the same way of thinking as Christ. “Since therefore Christ suffered in the flesh, arm yourselves with the same way of thinking, for whoever has suffered in the flesh has ceased from sin.” Suffering weans us from the old life. The time is past for doing what the Gentiles want, in sensuality and drunkenness; their surprise that you do not join them leads them to malign you. But they will give account to him who is ready to judge the living and the dead. “The end of all things is at hand; therefore be self-controlled and sober-minded for the sake of your prayers.”

Then the life of the church. “Above all, keep loving one another earnestly, since love covers a multitude of sins.” Show hospitality without grumbling. Every believer has a gift: “As each has received a gift, use it to serve one another, as good stewards of God’s varied grace: whoever speaks, as one who speaks oracles of God; whoever serves, as one who serves by the strength that God supplies, in order that in everything God may be glorified through Jesus Christ.” The gifts are for serving, and the aim is God’s glory.

Next, how to think about suffering: “Beloved, do not be surprised at the fiery trial when it comes upon you to test you, as though something strange were happening to you. But rejoice insofar as you share Christ’s sufferings, that you may also rejoice and be glad when his glory is revealed.” Suffering is not a sign that God has abandoned you; it is a share in Christ’s. “Blessed are you” if you are insulted for the name of Christ, for the Spirit of glory rests upon you. Only make sure you suffer for being a Christian and not for being a wrongdoer. “Yet if anyone suffers as a Christian, let him not be ashamed, but let him glorify God in that name.” The statement that judgment begins at the household of God (4:17) reminds us that God refines his own people first. Those who suffer according to God’s will should entrust their souls to a faithful Creator while doing good.

In chapter 5, Peter, “a fellow elder and a witness of the sufferings of Christ,” speaks to elders: “Shepherd the flock of God that is among you, exercising oversight, not under compulsion, but willingly, as God would have you; not for shameful gain, but eagerly; not domineering over those in your charge, but being examples to the flock. And when the chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the unfading crown of glory.” The younger are to be subject to the

elders. All are to clothe themselves with humility, “for God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble.” “Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God so that at the proper time he may exalt you, casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you.”

The final warning: “Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. Resist him, firm in your faith, knowing that the same kinds of suffering are being experienced by your brotherhood throughout the world.” The devil is real and fierce, but he is a lion on a leash. Then comes the promise: “And after you have suffered a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to his eternal glory in Christ, will himself restore, confirm, strengthen, and establish you. To him be the dominion forever and ever. Amen.” Peter signs off with greetings from Silvanus, from “she who is at Babylon” (the church in Rome), and from Mark, his son in the faith, with a final blessing: “Peace to all of you who are in Christ.”

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 12:6-8 and 1 Corinthians 12 discuss spiritual gifts. Proverbs 10:12 is behind 4:8. Matthew 5:10-12 blesses those persecuted. Acts 5:41 shows the apostles rejoicing in suffering. Philippians 3:10 speaks of sharing Christ’s sufferings. Ezekiel 9:6 and Malachi 3:1-6 relate to judgment beginning at God’s house. John 21:15-17 records Peter’s commission to feed the sheep. Ezekiel 34 and John 10 speak of shepherds. Psalm 55:22 is the source of 5:7. Job 1-2 shows Satan with limits. James 4:6-10 has a similar sequence of humility and resisting the devil.

STEP 6

Application

Identify a gift God has given you, and put it to use in your church this week.

If you are in a hard season, repeat 5:7 and name the specific worry that you are handing to God.

Ask whether you are “watchful” or complacent. What habit would help you stay alert and resist the devil?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Cast your anxieties on God, and name them.

Ask him to help you resist the devil and stand firm.

Thank him for the grace that called you to eternal glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

“But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen.”

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 850 · WEEK 122

2 Peter 1:1-21

The divine nature; the prophetic word confirmed

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Peter 1:1-21. This letter is Peter's last testimony, written as his death approaches. Notice the great promises, the call to grow, and the confidence he gives in the apostolic witness and the prophetic word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Peter writes his second letter shortly before his martyrdom, probably in the mid-60s AD. He knows that "the putting off of my body will be soon" (1:14), just as the Lord Jesus told him. His readers are in danger of false teachers who would draw them from the truth, so Peter wants to remind them of what they know. He calls himself Simeon Peter, a servant and apostle, and begins with the foundation of the whole Christian life: what God has already given us in Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "To those who have obtained a faith of equal standing with ours" (1:1).
2. "His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness" (1:3).
3. "That through them you may become partakers of the divine nature" (1:4).
4. "Make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue" (1:5).
5. "Be all the more diligent to make your calling and election sure" (1:10).
6. "For we did not follow cleverly devised myths when we made known to you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, but we were eyewitnesses of his majesty" (1:16).
7. "And we have something more sure, the prophetic word, to which you will do well to pay attention as to a lamp shining in a dark place" (1:19).

8 “Men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit” (1:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter greets those who have received “a faith of equal standing with ours,” which is to say the same faith that the apostles have, through the righteousness of “our God and Savior Jesus Christ.” Peter again calls Jesus God. Then he lays the foundation: “His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of him who called us to his own glory and excellence, by which he has granted to us his precious and very great promises, so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature, having escaped from the corruption that is in the world because of sinful desire.” Everything we need has already been given. To be a “partaker of the divine nature” does not mean we become God. The best reading is that, by union with Christ, we share in his moral likeness and the life he gives, escaping the corruption of sin. We are reborn into a new life and will be made like him.

Since God has given everything, Peter urges effort: “For this very reason, make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, and knowledge with self-control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, and godliness with brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love.” It is a ladder of growth with faith at the base and love at the top. “For if these qualities are yours and are increasing, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ.” The one who lacks them is nearsighted and has forgotten that he was cleansed from his former sins. “Therefore, brothers, be all the more diligent to make your calling and election sure, for if you practice these qualities you will never fall.” We do not make God’s election sure; we make it sure to us, confirming it by a transformed life. Then an entrance into the eternal kingdom will be supplied.

Peter then explains why he is writing. Soon he will die, and he wants them to remember these things. He does not rely on cleverly devised myths: “we were eyewitnesses of his majesty.” He was with Jesus on the mount of transfiguration and heard the voice from heaven: “This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased.” That experience confirmed the Old Testament prophets’ message: “And we have something more sure, the prophetic word, to which you will do well to pay attention as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts.”

Finally, Peter tells us how to understand Scripture: “knowing this first of all, that no prophecy of Scripture comes from someone’s own interpretation. For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy

Spirit." The point is about the origin of Scripture, not about private reading. The writers were human, but the Holy Spirit carried them, as a ship is carried by wind, so what they wrote is God's word. We examine this more on Day 851.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 17:1-8 records the transfiguration that Peter witnessed. John 21:18-19 records Jesus' prediction of Peter's death. Romans 8:28-30 speaks of calling and election. Galatians 5:22-23 lists the fruit of the Spirit. Colossians 1:10 calls for growth in the knowledge of God. Titus 3:5-7 and 1 John 3:2 speak of new birth and being like Christ. Psalm 119:105 describes the word as a lamp. Revelation 22:16 calls Christ the bright morning star. 2 Timothy 3:16 speaks of the inspiration of Scripture. 2 Timothy 4:6-8 is Paul's parallel farewell.

STEP 6

Application

Write out the seven qualities in verses 5 to 7 and rate yourself on each. Choose one to work on this week.

Memorize 1:3 and remind yourself that you already have everything you need for life and godliness in Christ.

Read the Bible today with a lamp-in-the-dark expectation: God will shed light on something.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for giving you everything you need for life and godliness.

Ask him to help you grow in virtue and knowledge.

Thank him for the prophetic word as a lamp.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 851 · WEEK 122

2 Peter 1:16-21; 2 Peter 3:15-16

Why these 66 books

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Doctrine · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Peter 1:16-21 and 2 Peter 3:15-16. Today is a doctrinal pause on the Bible itself: where it came from, why we have these sixty-six books, and why we trust them. Notice that Peter calls Paul's letters Scripture.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Christians believe the Bible is God's word, but where did the list of books come from? Who decided which were included? Were they chosen by councils or simply recognized? These questions matter, especially for new believers who may hear that the Bible was assembled by powerful men centuries after Jesus. The answer is that the church recognized books that already carried God's authority. Peter's letter gives us early evidence of this process.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For we did not follow cleverly devised myths" (2 Peter 1:16).
2. "And we have something more sure, the prophetic word" (2 Peter 1:19).
3. "No prophecy of Scripture comes from someone's own interpretation" (2 Peter 1:20).
4. "For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit" (2 Peter 1:21).
5. "Our beloved brother Paul also wrote to you according to the wisdom given him" (2 Peter 3:15).
6. "There are some things in them that are hard to understand" (2 Peter 3:16).
7. "Which the ignorant and unstable twist to their own destruction, as they do the other Scriptures" (2 Peter 3:16).

8 “And count the patience of our Lord as salvation” (2 Peter 3:15).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Bible is a library of sixty-six books: thirty-nine in the Old Testament and twenty-seven in the New, written over about fifteen hundred years by some forty human authors. Yet it is one story, because it has one divine author. Peter says that “men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit.” The human writers used their own personalities, styles, and research, and yet the product is God’s word. This is called inspiration. Because God is truthful, Scripture is also inerrant in what it affirms and sufficient for faith and life.

What is the canon? The word means “rule” or “standard.” The canon is the list of books recognized as the authoritative word of God. The church did not create the canon; it recognized it. Just as a person does not make a gold coin real by testing it, the church discerned which writings bore the marks of God’s voice.

The Old Testament canon. The Jewish community recognized the Law, the Prophets, and the Writings. Jesus and the apostles treated these as Scripture. Jesus spoke of “the Law of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms” (Luke 24:44) and referred to the span from Abel to Zechariah (Luke 11:51), which covers the Hebrew Bible from first to last. The New Testament quotes nearly every book of the Old Testament as authoritative. The books called the Apocrypha or deuterocanonical books (Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, 1-2 Maccabees, and others) were written in the period between the testaments. The Roman Catholic Church formally included most of them at the Council of Trent in 1546, and Eastern Orthodox churches also include some. Protestants, following the Hebrew canon recognized by Jesus’ contemporaries, do not accept them as Scripture, though many find them useful for history. Those who hold to the Reformation view note that these books are never quoted as Scripture by Jesus or the apostles.

The New Testament canon. Early Christians recognized three features: apostolic origin (written by an apostle or someone connected to an apostle’s authority), conformity to the apostolic teaching, and widespread, continuous use in the churches. The four Gospels and Paul’s letters were widely accepted very early. Peter himself refers to Paul’s letters alongside “the other Scriptures” (2 Peter 3:16), showing that within the lifetime of the apostles, their writings were beginning to be received as Scripture. Lists from the second century (such as the Muratorian fragment) already resemble ours. Athanasius in AD 367 listed the twenty-seven books, and councils at Hippo (393) and Carthage (397) affirmed them. These councils confirmed what the churches already knew.

Why trust it? We believe the Bible is God's word because of its own testimony, the witness of the Holy Spirit in believers, the character of Christ it reveals, its internal unity, and its historical reliability. And Jesus himself trusted the Scriptures: "Scripture cannot be broken" (John 10:35). If we trust Jesus, we trust the book he trusted. Because the apostles carry the authority he gave them, their writings complete the witness.

Peter also warns that Scripture can be twisted. Some of Paul's letters are hard to understand, and the ignorant and unstable twist them. We should read with humility, compare Scripture with Scripture, and seek help from the church.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter's first claim (1:16-18) is that the apostolic message is rooted in history. They did not follow clever myths. They were eyewitnesses. This is a concern about the truth of what happened, and it is the basis for the New Testament's authority.

The second claim (1:19-21) is that the Old Testament prophets spoke by God. The verb "carried along" is the same used of a ship driven by the wind in Acts 27:15. The Spirit moved the authors, so that their words were truly theirs and truly God's. The statement that no prophecy comes "from someone's own interpretation" is best understood to mean that no prophet made up his message; the origin is God, not the prophet's own insight. It also reminds us that interpretation matters: we should not twist Scripture to say what we want.

The third claim (3:15-16) is that Paul's letters are among "the other Scriptures." This is a remarkable thing for one apostle to say of another. It is also worth noting the humility of Peter: he admits some things in Paul are "hard to understand." Even apostles had to wrestle with Scripture, which should encourage us when we find it hard.

Practically, this teaches us three things. First, we can trust the Bible because it comes from God. Second, we should study it carefully, because errors in interpretation have real consequences. Third, we should read it in the community of the church, where gifted teachers help us understand it.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Timothy 3:16-17 and Hebrews 1:1-2 speak of God's word through prophets and his Son. Luke 24:25-27 and 24:44-47 show Jesus reading the Old Testament about himself. John 10:35 says Scripture cannot be broken. Matthew 5:17-18 affirms the Law and the Prophets. John 14:26 and 16:13 promise the Spirit's help to the apostles. 1 Thessalonians 2:13 says the word is

received as the word of God. 1 Timothy 5:18 quotes Luke as Scripture. Revelation 22:18-19 warns against adding to or taking away. Psalm 19:7-11 praises the word of the LORD. Acts 8:30-35 shows Philip explaining Scripture.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God today for the Bible and for the people who preserved and translated it.

If you have doubts about the Bible's reliability, write down your questions and bring them to a pastor or a trusted friend. Many good books address them.

Read one passage this week that is "hard to understand," and use a study Bible or commentary to help.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for giving you his word through the prophets and apostles.
- Ask him to help you trust it as his word.
- Ask him to give you a hunger for all of it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 852 · WEEK 122

2 Peter 2:1-3:18

False teachers; the day of the Lord

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Peter 2:1-3:18. The first chapter warns against false teachers, and the second looks ahead to the day of the Lord. Notice Peter's use of Old Testament examples and his answer to the scoffers who ask, "Where is the promise of his coming?"

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Peter's readers were threatened by false teachers who were morally lax and who mocked the idea that Christ would return. Peter's response is stern about the teachers (chapter 2) and pastoral toward the believers (chapter 3). The letter has many similarities to Jude, and many scholars think Peter and Jude drew on a common warning. The second chapter is among the strongest descriptions of false teaching in the Bible.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "There will be false teachers among you, who will secretly bring in destructive heresies" (2:1).
2. "Then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trials" (2:9).
3. "Scoffers will come in the last days with scoffing" (3:3).
4. "Where is the promise of his coming?" (3:4).
5. "With the Lord one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day" (3:8).
6. "The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance" (3:9).

7. “According to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells” (3:13).

8. “But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ” (3:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter says that just as false prophets arose in Israel, “there will be false teachers among you, who will secretly bring in destructive heresies, even denying the Master who bought them, bringing upon themselves swift destruction.” They are known by their doctrine and their lives: many will follow their sensuality, and because of them the way of truth will be blasphemed. They exploit others with false words. But judgment is certain. Peter gives three examples: the angels who sinned and were cast into hell, the ancient world destroyed by the flood (with Noah preserved as a herald of righteousness), and Sodom and Gomorrah (with Lot rescued). “Then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trials, and to keep the unrighteous under punishment until the day of judgment.” God both saves and judges.

The false teachers are described vividly: following the flesh in corrupt desire, despising authority, bold and willful, “like irrational animals.” They are “springs without water and mists driven by a storm.” They promise freedom, “but they themselves are slaves of corruption.” Peter says it would have been better never to have known the way of righteousness than to turn back from it, as a dog returns to its vomit and a washed sow to wallowing in the mire.

Chapter 3 begins with a reminder. Peter writes to stir up their sincere minds to remember the words of the prophets and the apostles. “Knowing this first of all, that scoffers will come in the last days with scoffing, following their own sinful desires. They will say, Where is the promise of his coming? For ever since the fathers fell asleep, all things are continuing as they were from the beginning of creation.” Peter answers: they forget that God created the world by his word, and that the same word destroyed the world by water and now holds the present heavens and earth for fire. Delay is not slowness. “With the Lord one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day.” God is not bound by our clock. “The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance.” Delay is mercy. Christians who hold to unconditional election read “you” as the elect, God’s people, for whom he waits until all are gathered. Others read “all” broadly as God’s desire for every person. Either way, patience calls for repentance.

“But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, and then the heavens will pass away with a roar, and the elements will be dissolved with heat, and the earth and the works that are done on it will be exposed.” Interpreters debate whether this means the complete destruction of

the present creation or its purging and renewal by fire, as metal is refined. Many hold the latter, noting the comparison to Noah's flood, which did not annihilate the earth. The end result is clear: "According to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells."

So what kind of people should we be? "Since all these things are thus to be dissolved, what sort of people ought you to be in lives of holiness and godliness, waiting for and hastening the coming of the day of God?" Be diligent to be found without spot or blemish, at peace. Beware of being carried away with the error of lawless people. And the closing charge: "But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

STEP 5

Connection

Jude 4-19 closely parallels chapter 2. Genesis 6-8 and 19 record the flood and Sodom. Numbers 22-24 tells the story of Balaam. Proverbs 26:11 is quoted in 2:22. Psalm 90:4 stands behind 3:8. Matthew 24:36-44 and 1 Thessalonians 5:2 describe the Lord coming like a thief. Habakkuk 2:3 speaks of waiting for a delayed vision. Romans 2:4 says God's kindness leads to repentance. 1 Timothy 2:4 says God desires all to be saved. Isaiah 65:17 and 66:22 promise new heavens and a new earth. Romans 8:19-23 and Revelation 21:1-5 describe the renewed creation.

STEP 6

Application

Test the teaching you hear against Scripture. Ask where it comes from, what it says about Christ, and what kind of lives its teachers lead.

Reframe a delay in your own life, such as an unanswered prayer or a waiting season, in light of 3:8-9. How might God be showing patience?

Pick one way to "grow in grace and knowledge" this week, such as a book of the Bible or a theological book.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from false teachers.

Thank him that he knows how to rescue the godly.

Ask him to help you grow in grace and in knowledge of Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 853 · WEEK 122

Psalm 34

Taste and see that the LORD is good

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 34. David praises God for rescue and invites others to taste and see. Notice the movement from personal testimony to teaching, and the promises to the brokenhearted and the righteous.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The heading says this is a psalm "of David, when he changed his behavior before Abimelech, so that he drove him out, and he went away." It looks back on 1 Samuel 21:10-15, when David, fleeing Saul, went to the Philistine king and pretended to be insane to save his life. The psalm is an acrostic, each verse beginning with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet. It is a thanksgiving for deliverance and a teaching psalm. Peter quotes it in his first letter (1 Peter 2:3 and 3:10-12), so it is a natural companion to our reading.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will bless the LORD at all times; his praise shall continually be in my mouth" (v. 1).
2. "I sought the LORD, and he answered me and delivered me from all my fears" (v. 4).
3. "Those who look to him are radiant, and their faces shall never be ashamed" (v. 5).
4. "The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear him, and delivers them" (v. 7).
5. "Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!" (v. 8).
6. "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit" (v. 18).
7. "Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him out of them all" (v. 19).

8 “The LORD redeems the life of his servants; none of those who take refuge in him will be condemned” (v. 22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with a commitment: “I will bless the LORD at all times; his praise shall continually be in my mouth.” Not only when things go well, and not only when he is in the temple. This praise comes from a man who has just escaped by his wits and who admits that the credit belongs to the LORD. He invites others: “Oh, magnify the LORD with me, and let us exalt his name together!” Then his story: “I sought the LORD, and he answered me and delivered me from all my fears.” This poor man (the afflicted) cried, and the LORD heard him and saved him out of all his troubles. “The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear him, and delivers them.”

The center of the psalm is the invitation: “Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!” Faith is not only believing; it is experiencing. We do not just analyze whether a meal is good; we taste it. God invites us to try him and find that he is good. Peter picks up the image in 1 Peter 2:3, speaking of those who have “tasted that the Lord is good.” David notes that young lions suffer want and hunger, “but those who seek the LORD lack no good thing.”

Then David moves into a teaching mode: “Come, O children, listen to me; I will teach you the fear of the LORD.” The fear of the LORD includes keeping the tongue from evil, turning from evil and doing good, and seeking peace. “The eyes of the LORD are toward the righteous and his ears toward their cry. The face of the LORD is against those who do evil.” Peter quotes these verses to encourage persecuted Christians that God sees their suffering.

The psalm’s most tender promise is verse 18: “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit.” God does not stand far off from the hurting. And it is honest about suffering: “Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him out of them all. He keeps all his bones; not one of them is broken.” John quotes this verse in John 19:36, seeing it fulfilled in Jesus on the cross: not one of his bones was broken. The righteous sufferer ultimately is Christ. And the psalm ends with the promise to all who trust in him: “The LORD redeems the life of his servants; none of those who take refuge in him will be condemned.”

STEP 5

Connection

1 Samuel 21:10-15 is the background story. 1 Peter 2:3 and 3:10-12 quote and allude to this psalm. John 19:36 sees verse 20 fulfilled. Psalm 27:13 and 119:103 also speak of tasting God's goodness. Isaiah 57:15 and 61:1 speak of the brokenhearted. Psalm 51:17 says God does not despise a broken heart. Luke 4:18 has Jesus bind up the brokenhearted. Romans 8:1 and 8:31-39 declare no condemnation. Matthew 4:11 and Hebrews 1:14 refer to angels serving. Romans 8:28 says God works for the good of those who love him.

STEP 6

Application

Practice taste and see: pause at one point today and thank God for something specific, noticing his goodness.

If you are brokenhearted, read verse 18 slowly and pray it as your own. If you know someone who is, sit with them.

Tell someone else about a time God delivered you, as David did in verses 1 to 6.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bless the LORD at this moment, in your own words.
- Thank him for delivering you from fears.
- Ask him to help you taste and see his goodness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 122

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

DAY 854 · WEEK 122

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Peter 3:18 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen."

2 PETER 3:18

REST

Meditation

These are Peter's last written words, and they are a command to keep growing. After warnings about false teachers and scoffers, his remedy is not only to guard but to grow. A healthy plant resists disease. A Christian who grows in grace and knowledge is harder to lead astray.

Grace comes first. We grow in the grace of God, receiving more of his kindness and being shaped by it. Knowledge comes second: not just information, but knowing Christ more deeply. The two go together; knowledge without grace puffs up, and grace without knowledge stays shallow.

Notice the object: "our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ." Growth is growth toward and into him. And the verse ends with praise: "To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity." Our growth is for his glory. Ask the Lord today where he wants you to grow.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the rest of 1 Peter and all of 2 Peter. First Peter 2 and 3 called us to honor everyone, follow the example of Christ who bore our sins on the tree, and always be ready to explain our hope with gentleness and respect. First Peter 4 and 5 taught us to love earnestly, use our gifts as good stewards, not be surprised by fiery trials, shepherd willingly, cast our anxieties on God, resist the roaring lion, and trust the God of all grace. Second Peter 1 told us that God has given us everything we need for life and godliness and urged us to add virtue to our faith. On Day 851 we paused on the origin and canon of Scripture. Second Peter 2 and 3 warned us about false teachers and scoffers and pointed to the patience of the Lord and the new heavens and new earth. Psalm 34 invited us to taste and see that the LORD is good.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Peter says to be ready to give a defense for the hope that is in you with gentleness and respect. What is your hope, and how would you explain it in two minutes to a neighbor who asked?

Peter says to cast all your anxieties on God because he cares for you. What anxiety are you carrying right now? What would it look like to hand it to him in prayer today?

Peter's final words are to grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. In what area do you most want to grow in the next month, and what is one practical step?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for rest and for his word.

Ask him to help you grow in grace and knowledge.

Rest in his provision.

DAY 855 · WEEK 123

Psalm 118:1-18

His steadfast love endures forever

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 118:1-18. This is the last of the Hallel psalms (113 to 118), which Jews sang at Passover and which Jesus and his disciples most likely sang at the Last Supper. Notice how often the psalm repeats "the LORD" and how the speaker moves from distress to victory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 118 is a song of thanksgiving for a national and personal deliverance, sung in procession to the temple. The speaker is a king or leader who has been surrounded by enemies and brought through. The Hallel was sung at the great feasts, and the New Testament treats this psalm as pointing to Christ: the stone the builders rejected (v. 22) and "Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD" (v. 26) were cried at Jesus' entry into Jerusalem. Today we read the first part, which focuses on God's steadfast love and salvation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!" (v. 1).
2. "Out of my distress I called on the LORD; the LORD answered me and set me free" (v. 5).
3. "The LORD is on my side; I will not fear. What can man do to me?" (v. 6).
4. "It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man" (v. 8).
5. "All nations surrounded me; in the name of the LORD I cut them off!" (v. 10).
6. "I was pushed hard, so that I was falling, but the LORD helped me" (v. 13).
7. "The LORD is my strength and my song; he has become my salvation" (v. 14).
8. "I shall not die, but I shall live, and recount the deeds of the LORD" (v. 17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins and ends with the same words: “Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!” Israel, the house of Aaron, and all who fear the LORD are called to say it. “Steadfast love” (hesed) is God’s covenant faithfulness, a love that does not let go. It is the refrain of the exodus and of the whole Old Testament. Later we will read in 1 John that “God is love,” and the two belong together. The love that endures forever is the love that sent the Son.

Then the testimony: “Out of my distress I called on the LORD; the LORD answered me and set me free.” The Hebrew for “set me free” is “in a broad place,” meaning out of tight distress into open space. From this the singer draws a conclusion: “The LORD is on my side; I will not fear. What can man do to me?” Paul takes up the same confidence in Romans 8:31: “If God is for us, who can be against us?” The LORD is my helper, and I shall look in triumph on those who hate me. Then a proverb: “It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man. It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in princes.” Human help is limited; God’s help is not.

Verses 10 to 12 describe the enemies swarming like bees, flaming like a fire of thorns. Three times the singer says, “In the name of the LORD I cut them off.” Victory is not in his strength but in God’s name. Then verse 13 is honest about how close it was: “I was pushed hard, so that I was falling, but the LORD helped me.” We should not minimize the near-failure. And at the center, a line borrowed from the Song of Moses (Exodus 15:2): “The LORD is my strength and my song; he has become my salvation.” Glad songs of salvation are heard in the tents of the righteous: “The right hand of the LORD does valiantly.”

The speaker concludes this section with a statement of resurrection language: “I shall not die, but I shall live, and recount the deeds of the LORD. The LORD has disciplined me severely, but he has not given me over to death.” He has been chastened but not condemned. For the singer, it is deliverance from literal death; for Christians, it points to Christ, who died and rose, and to all who are in him. He sang this psalm on the night he was betrayed, knowing what lay ahead. And the God whose love endures forever did not abandon him to the grave.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 15:2 is quoted in verse 14. Psalm 56:4, 11 and Romans 8:31 echo verse 6. Jeremiah 17:5-8 contrasts trust in man and trust in the LORD. Psalm 146:3 warns against trusting princes. Matthew 26:30 and Mark 14:26 say Jesus and the disciples sang a hymn, probably the

Hallel. Matthew 21:9, 42 apply verses 22 and 26 to Jesus. Acts 4:11 and 1 Peter 2:7 quote verse 22. Hebrews 12:5-11 speaks of the Lord's discipline. 1 John 4:8-10 speaks of God's love. 2 Corinthians 1:8-10 describes deliverance from the sentence of death.

STEP 6

Application

Read verse 1 aloud at the start of the day, and name three specific ways you have seen God's steadfast love in the last week.

Name a person or institution in which you are placing too much trust. Entrust that situation to the LORD.

Memorize verse 14 as a short prayer when you feel weak.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give thanks to God for his steadfast love.

Thank him that the LORD is on your side.

Thank him for the stone the builders rejected.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 856 · WEEK 123

Psalm 31:1-8

Into your hands I commit my spirit

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 31:1-8. This is a prayer of refuge by David. Notice the rock and fortress language and the line that Jesus prayed from the cross.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 31 is a psalm of David written in a time of distress, perhaps when he was hunted by Saul. It contains a mixture of confident trust, honest lament, and thanksgiving. The first eight verses are mostly trust. Verse 5 holds special significance because Jesus used it as his final prayer on the cross (Luke 23:46), and so did Stephen as he died (Acts 7:59). Many saints through history have prayed it at the end of their lives.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “In you, O LORD, do I take refuge; let me never be put to shame; in your righteousness deliver me!” (v. 1).
2. “Be a rock of refuge for me, a strong fortress to save me!” (v. 2).
3. “For you are my rock and my fortress” (v. 3).
4. “You take me out of the net they have hidden for me, for you are my refuge” (v. 4).
5. “Into your hand I commit my spirit; you have redeemed me, O LORD, faithful God” (v. 5).
6. “But I trust in the LORD” (v. 6).
7. “I will rejoice and be glad in your steadfast love, because you have seen my affliction” (v. 7).
8. “You have set my feet in a broad place” (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with a plea built on God's character: "In you, O LORD, do I take refuge; let me never be put to shame; in your righteousness deliver me!" He appeals not to his own righteousness but to God's. He asks God to incline his ear, to rescue speedily, and to be a rock of refuge and a strong fortress. Then he states a conviction: "For you are my rock and my fortress; and for your name's sake you lead me and guide me." God's reputation is bound up with his people. Because his name is good, he can be trusted to guide.

The enemies have set a trap: "You take me out of the net they have hidden for me, for you are my refuge." David is not just fleeing; he is looking to God to pull him from danger he cannot see.

Then the line that has comforted generations: "Into your hand I commit my spirit; you have redeemed me, O LORD, faithful God." For David, it was a prayer of trust at a time of danger, committing his life into God's hand. It is a daily prayer, like a rest at night. And since Jesus prayed it at his death (adding "Father"), it became the prayer of the dying. When Jesus said it, he was committing himself into the hands of the Father who would raise him. For the believer, to commit our spirit to God is to trust him with our life now and our death at the end.

David contrasts his trust with that of those who "pay regard to worthless idols." Idols cannot rescue. He rejoices in God's steadfast love, "because you have seen my affliction; you have known the distress of my soul, and you have not delivered me into the hand of the enemy; you have set my feet in a broad place." God sees, knows, and brings out into the open. The tightness of danger gives way to wide places.

Verses 9 to 18 turn to lament, describing David's grief, his friends' abandonment, and his plot-ridden enemies. There David says, "But I trust in you, O LORD; I say, You are my God. My times are in your hand" (vv. 14-15). The psalm ends with a call to the saints to love the LORD and to be strong and take courage, all you who wait for him (vv. 23-24).

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 23:46 and Acts 7:59 quote verse 5. Psalm 18:2, 71:1-3, and 91:2 use rock and fortress language. Psalm 25:2-3 also asks not to be put to shame. Psalm 18:19 and 118:5 speak of a broad place. Jonah 2:8 also refers to idols. Isaiah 41:10 and Romans 8:31-39 offer similar assurance. 1 Peter 4:19 speaks of entrusting our souls to a faithful Creator. Hebrews 5:7-9 speaks of Jesus' prayers. John 10:28-29 speaks of being held in the hand of Jesus and the Father. 2 Timothy 1:12 expresses a similar confidence in what Christ guards.

STEP 6

Application

Pray verse 5 tonight as you go to sleep, committing your spirit and tomorrow into God's hand.

Think of a situation that feels like a tight place. Ask God to set your feet in a broad place.

If you are afraid of death, memorize verse 5 and remember who prayed it first.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Take refuge in God, and tell him why.
- Commit your spirit into his hands.
- Ask him to lead and guide you for his name's sake.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 857 · WEEK 123

1 John 1:1-2:29

The word of life; walking in light; the antichrists

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 John 1:1-2:29. John writes as an eyewitness of Jesus and gives tests by which his readers can know that they have eternal life. Notice the repeated themes of light and darkness, truth and lies, and love and hate.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The apostle John, the last living eyewitness, wrote this letter in his old age, probably from Ephesus in the 80s or 90s AD. A group had left the church (2:19), claiming a higher knowledge, denying that Jesus had come in the flesh, and living as though sin did not matter. John writes to assure true believers and expose the counterfeit. There is no formal greeting; he begins like a sermon. His message is simple and deep: the God who is light and love has come to us in Jesus, and those who know him walk in the light and love one another.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “That which we have heard, which we have seen with our eyes, which we looked upon and have touched with our hands” (1:1).
2. “God is light, and in him is no darkness at all” (1:5).
3. “The blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin” (1:7).
4. “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1:9).
5. “We have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous” (2:1).
6. “He is the propitiation for our sins” (2:2).
7. “Do not love the world or the things in the world” (2:15).

8 “They went out from us, but they were not of us” (2:19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John begins by insisting that the Word of life was heard, seen, and touched. The Christian faith is not a myth or an idea but the testimony of those who handled the incarnate Son. The purpose of this witness is fellowship: “that you too may have fellowship with us; and indeed our fellowship is with the Father and with his Son Jesus Christ.” He writes “that our joy may be complete.”

The message is this: “God is light, and in him is no darkness at all.” Then John gives three false claims and three true responses. If we claim fellowship with him while walking in darkness, we lie. But “if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin.” If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves. But “if we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.” He is faithful (he keeps his promises) and just (the price was paid by Christ). If we say we have not sinned, we make him a liar. Walking in the light does not mean sinless perfection; it means honest confession.

Chapter 2 opens tenderly. “My little children, I am writing these things to you so that you may not sin. But if anyone does sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous. He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the whole world.” Propitiation means the sacrifice that turns aside God’s wrath. Christ is both the advocate who pleads for us and the sacrifice that makes the plea valid. The phrase “the whole world” has been understood in different ways: that Christ’s sacrifice is sufficient for all and sincerely offered to all, or (as many Reformed interpreters hold) that it is for people from every nation and not for Jews only. Either way, the focus is on the sufficiency and reach of his work.

The tests of knowing God are obedience and love. “And by this we know that we have come to know him, if we keep his commandments.” Whoever says he abides in him ought to walk as he walked. The old commandment is a new commandment that is true in Christ: whoever loves his brother abides in the light; whoever hates his brother is in darkness. John then addresses children, fathers, and young men with a message of forgiveness, knowledge of him who is from the beginning, and victory over the evil one.

The second warning is against the world: “Do not love the world or the things in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him. For all that is in the world, the desires of the flesh and the desires of the eyes and pride in possessions, is not from the Father but is from the world. And the world is passing away along with its desires, but whoever does the will of God abides forever.”

The final section warns about antichrists. “Children, it is the last hour, and as you have heard that antichrist is coming, so now many antichrists have come.” The last hour began with Christ’s first coming. The antichrists denied that Jesus is the Christ. “They went out from us, but they were not of us; for if they had been of us, they would have continued with us. But they went out, so that it might become plain that they all are not of us.” Departure revealed their true nature. By contrast, believers have an anointing from the Holy One and know the truth. John exhorts: “And now, little children, abide in him, so that when he appears we may have confidence and not shrink from him in shame at his coming.”

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:1-14 and Luke 24:39 relate to the eyewitness testimony. Psalm 32:1-5 and Proverbs 28:13 speak of confession. Romans 3:25 and Hebrews 2:17 use propitiation language. Romans 8:34 and Hebrews 7:25 describe Christ’s intercession. John 13:34-35 gives the new commandment. Genesis 3:6 echoes the three desires in 2:16. Matthew 24:24 and 2 Thessalonians 2 speak of antichrists. John 14:26 and 16:13 promise the Spirit as teacher. Hebrews 6:4-6 and 10:26-31 speak of falling away. John 6:66-69 shows disciples who left Jesus.

STEP 6

Application

Confess a specific sin today. Believe the promise of 1:9 and receive the forgiveness: he is faithful and just.

When you sin this week, remember you have an advocate. Run to him, not away.

Examine your loves. What “world” desire has been competing with the love of the Father?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he is light, and ask him to help you walk in it.
- Confess your sin and thank him for forgiving it.
- Ask him to keep you from loving the world.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 858 · WEEK 123

1 John 3:1-24

Children of God; love as the test of genuine faith

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 John 3:1-24. John speaks of the great love of the Father, the family likeness of God's children, and love as the test of life. Notice the contrast between the children of God and the children of the devil.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In this chapter John continues his tests of genuine faith. These tests are not given to make believers anxious but to give assurance. Those who have been born of God will show a family likeness: they practice righteousness, they turn from sin, and they love their brothers and sisters. Cain is the example of the opposite. At the center is the cross as the pattern of love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are" (v. 1).
2. "When he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is" (v. 2).
3. "The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil" (v. 8).
4. "No one born of God makes a practice of sinning" (v. 9).
5. "We know that we have passed out of death into life, because we love the brothers" (v. 14).
6. "By this we know love, that he laid down his life for us, and we ought to lay down our lives for the brothers" (v. 16).
7. "Little children, let us not love in word or talk but in deed and in truth" (v. 18).

8 “For whenever our heart condemns us, God is greater than our heart, and he knows everything” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John begins with amazement: “See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are.” We are not just treated as children; we are children. The world does not recognize us, because it did not know him. And the future is greater: “Beloved, we are God’s children now, and what we will be has not yet appeared; but we know that when he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is. And everyone who thus hopes in him purifies himself as he is pure.” The hope of seeing Christ and being like him is a power for holiness now.

Then comes the connection between sin and the new birth. “Everyone who makes a practice of sinning also practices lawlessness; sin is lawlessness.” Christ appeared to take away sins, and in him there is no sin. “The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil.” Then the verse that has puzzled many: “No one born of God makes a practice of sinning, for God’s seed abides in him, and he cannot keep on sinning because he has been born of God.” Taken alone it seems to teach sinless perfection, but John already said in 1:8 that anyone who claims to be without sin is a liar. The verbs in the Greek are in the present tense and describe continuous, habitual action. A child of God may sin but cannot settle into sin as a way of life, because a new nature has been planted in him. So the children of God and the children of the devil are manifest: “Whoever does not practice righteousness is not of God, nor is the one who does not love his brother.”

The message from the beginning: “that we should love one another.” Not like Cain, who murdered his brother because his deeds were evil. “Do not be surprised, brothers, that the world hates you.” And then: “We know that we have passed out of death into life, because we love the brothers. Whoever does not love abides in death.” The Christian does not love in order to receive life; love is the evidence that life has been received.

The definition of love is the cross: “By this we know love, that he laid down his life for us, and we ought to lay down our lives for the brothers.” This leads to a very practical word: “But if anyone has the world’s goods and sees his brother in need, yet closes his heart against him, how does God’s love abide in him? Little children, let us not love in word or talk but in deed and in truth.” By this, we know that we are of the truth and reassure our heart before him.

Then a pastoral comfort for troubled consciences: “For whenever our heart condemns us, God is greater than our heart, and he knows everything.” Some read this as comfort: even when our conscience accuses us, God knows our sincere desire to love him and is greater than our accusing heart. Others read it as a warning that God sees all. In context, comfort is

the more natural meaning. The chapter ends with the twin commands: “that we believe in the name of his Son Jesus Christ and love one another.” And the one who keeps his commandments abides in God, and God in him, and “we know by this that he abides in us, by the Spirit whom he has given us.”

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:12-13 and Romans 8:14-17 speak of becoming children of God. Philippians 3:20-21 and Romans 8:29 promise we will be like Christ. Genesis 3:15 and Colossians 2:15 speak of the defeat of the devil. Genesis 4:1-12 is the story of Cain. John 5:24 says believers have passed from death to life. John 15:13 says there is no greater love than laying down one’s life. Romans 5:8 shows God’s love in Christ’s death. Matthew 25:31-46 ties judgment to care for the needy. James 2:15-17 repeats the point about love in deed. Romans 8:1 and 8:16 offer assurance for the condemning heart.

STEP 6

Application

Spend time with verse 1 and let it sink in: you are a child of God. Thank the Father for his lavish love.

Look for one practical way to love “in deed and in truth” this week, perhaps meeting a financial or practical need in your church.

If your heart condemns you, pray verse 20 and rest in God’s greater knowledge and mercy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the love that makes you his child.
- Ask him to teach you to love in deed and truth.
- Ask him to give you assurance.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 859 · WEEK 123

1 John 4:1-5:21

Test the spirits; God is love; assurance

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 John 4:1-5:21. John gives more tests, including testing the spirits, and reaches the heights in his teaching on God's love. The letter ends with a statement of its purpose: that you may know that you have eternal life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In these chapters John returns to the tests of true faith: believing that Jesus has come in the flesh, loving one another, and obeying God's commands. He is concerned about false prophets who deny the incarnation. He lays out the foundation of Christian love in the character of God and the love of Christ. The letter closes with assurance and the confidence that believers can pray according to God's will.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God" (4:1).
2. "Anyone who does not love does not know God, because God is love" (4:8).
3. "In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins" (4:10).
4. "There is no fear in love, but perfect love casts out fear" (4:18).
5. "We love because he first loved us" (4:19).
6. "For this is the love of God, that we keep his commandments. And his commandments are not burdensome" (5:3).

7. “I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God that you may know that you have eternal life” (5:13).

8. “Little children, keep yourselves from idols” (5:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John tells his readers to test every spirit, because many false prophets are in the world. The test is confessing that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh. Anyone who denies this is the spirit of the antichrist. But “he who is in you is greater than he who is in the world.” This is the first central theme: truth.

The second theme is love. “Beloved, let us love one another, for love is from God, and whoever loves has been born of God and knows God. Anyone who does not love does not know God, because God is love.” This is not just a description of God’s feelings; it is who he is. And where do we see this love? “In this the love of God was made manifest among us, that God sent his only Son into the world, so that we might live through him. In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins.” Love begins with God, not with us. And “if God so loved us, we also ought to love one another.” No one has ever seen God, but if we love one another, God abides in us and his love is perfected in us. The Spirit he has given us is the assurance that we abide in him.

Verse 18 is a comfort: “There is no fear in love, but perfect love casts out fear. For fear has to do with punishment, and whoever fears has not been perfected in love.” When we are sure of the Father’s love, we do not fear final punishment. And then the memory verse of the unit: “We love because he first loved us.” Our love is a response. And finally the test: “If anyone says, I love God, and hates his brother, he is a liar; for he who does not love his brother whom he has seen cannot love God whom he has not seen.”

Chapter 5 states that everyone who believes that Jesus is the Christ has been born of God. Love for God means keeping his commandments, “and his commandments are not burdensome. For everyone who has been born of God overcomes the world.” The victory is our faith. Who is it that overcomes the world except the one who believes that Jesus is the Son of God? John then speaks of the three witnesses: the Spirit, the water, and the blood, which agree. Most interpreters understand these as Jesus’ baptism, his death on the cross, and the Spirit’s testimony. (Some older English translations include an additional clause about “the Father, the Word, and the Holy Spirit” in verse 7, which is not found in the earliest Greek manuscripts.)

The great purpose statement: “And this is the testimony, that God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life. I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God that you may know that you have eternal life.” Assurance is possible, and it is what the whole letter aims at. He then gives confidence in prayer: “if we ask anything according to his will he hears us.” There is mention of a “sin that leads to death” (5:16-17), which interpreters take differently: a persistent, public rejection of Christ, or apostasy, or a sin bringing physical death. The point is that we should pray for our brothers, and that all wrongdoing is sin. We know that everyone born of God does not keep on sinning, that the Son of God keeps him, and that the evil one does not touch him. The final words, “Little children, keep yourselves from idols,” are a call to cling to the true God.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 13:1-5 and 1 Corinthians 12:3 speak of testing prophets. Romans 5:8 and John 3:16 are other statements of God’s love. Exodus 34:6-7 declares God’s steadfast love. Romans 8:15 says we have not received a spirit of fear but of adoption. Matthew 22:36-40 joins loving God and neighbor. John 14:15 says if you love me, you will keep my commandments. Matthew 11:30 speaks of an easy yoke. John 16:33 says Christ has overcome the world. John 20:31 states a similar purpose. Hebrews 6:4-8 and 10:26-31 relate to the sin leading to death. Exodus 20:3-5 forbids idols.

STEP 6

Application

Think of a teaching you recently heard. Test it by what it says about Christ.

Read 4:9-10 again. Whom do you find difficult to love? Ask God to help you love them as he has loved you.

Write down 5:13 on a card and keep it where you see it as a reminder that you can know you have eternal life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is love and sent his Son.

Ask him to help you love because he first loved you.

Ask him to strengthen your assurance.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 860 · WEEK 123

John 10:27-30; Romans 8:31-39; 1 John 5:11-13

Perseverance and Assurance

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 10:27-30, Romans 8:31-39, and 1 John 5:11-13. Today is a doctrinal pause on perseverance and assurance. Notice the language of security and the repeated phrase “no one” and “nothing” can separate us from Christ.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Two questions trouble many Christians. First: can a true believer lose his salvation? Second: how can I know that I am really saved? The first is the doctrine of perseverance, and the second is the doctrine of assurance. They are related but distinct. Christians have answered them in different ways, so we proceed carefully and with charity, and we let Scripture speak.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me” (John 10:27).
2. “I give them eternal life, and they will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand” (John 10:28).
3. “No one is able to snatch them out of the Father’s hand” (John 10:29).
4. “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31).
5. “Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?” (Romans 8:35).
6. “Will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:39).
7. “Whoever has the Son has life” (1 John 5:12).

8 “I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God that you may know that you have eternal life” (1 John 5:13).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Perseverance of the saints is the teaching that all those truly born again will be kept by God and will persevere in faith to the end. They are kept not by their own strength but by God’s power (1 Peter 1:5). Those who fall away finally show they were never truly of us (1 John 2:19). This is the view of Reformed churches and of many Baptists and other evangelicals, sometimes expressed as “eternal security” or “once saved, always saved,” though the first phrase is better because it stresses that true believers do persevere.

The case for perseverance rests on the promises of God. Jesus says his sheep “will never perish, and no one will snatch them out of my hand.” Paul says that those God predestined, he called; those he called, he justified; and those he justified, he glorified (Romans 8:30), with no loss along the chain. He is “sure that neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers… will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord.” Philippians 1:6 promises that he who began a good work will bring it to completion. Jude 24 says he is able to keep us from stumbling. Salvation depends on God’s faithfulness, not ours.

Other Christians, especially in Arminian and Wesleyan traditions, hold that a true believer can, through persistent unbelief and rejection of Christ, fall from grace. They point to warning passages such as Hebrews 6:4-6, 10:26-31, and 2 Peter 2:20-22, and to Jesus’ words in John 15:1-6 about branches that do not abide. Many in this tradition affirm that believers have a strong security in Christ and that falling away is not a casual matter, but rather a deliberate abandonment of faith. Both sides take the warnings seriously. The Reformed answer is that the warnings are real means God uses to keep his people persevering: they are warnings to those who profess faith but may not have it, and they are God’s way of causing true believers to hold fast. Perseverance is something believers do, empowered by God.

Assurance is the confidence that I am a child of God. John says this is the purpose of his letter (1 John 5:13). Assurance rests on three supports. First, the promises of God in Scripture: whoever believes in him has eternal life. Second, the inward witness of the Holy Spirit, who testifies with our spirit that we are children of God (Romans 8:16). Third, the fruit in our lives: growing love, obedience, and hatred of sin. A person may be truly saved but lack assurance for a time, because of sin, depression, or weak understanding. Assurance can grow, and it is a gift to pray for.

How should we hold the doctrine? With humility and care. The warnings keep us from presumption, and the promises keep us from despair. A believer who struggles with doubt should look away from his own performance to Christ, who holds him. A person who is

careless should hear the warnings. Our confidence is not in our grip on Christ, but in his grip on us.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In John 10, Jesus describes his sheep: they hear his voice, he knows them, and they follow him. Note that the description includes following, which is a mark of true sheep. He gives them eternal life, and they will never perish. The security is double: they are in his hand and in the Father's hand. The ground is that "I and the Father are one": the power that holds us is the unlimited power of God.

Romans 8 builds an argument from God's love. If God gave his own Son for us, will he not give us all things? Who will bring a charge against God's elect? God is the one who justifies. Who is to condemn? Christ Jesus is the one who died, who was raised, who is at the right hand of God, who intercedes for us. Then the great list of possible threats: tribulation, distress, persecution, famine, nakedness, danger, sword; death, life, angels, rulers, things present, things to come, powers, height, depth, anything else in all creation. None can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord. This is a promise for those in Christ and rests on what Christ has done.

First John 5 ties assurance to the possession of the Son. "And this is the testimony, that God gave us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life." The question is whether we have the Son. If we believe in his name, we have life, and God wants us to know it.

STEP 5

Connection

Philippians 1:6 and Jude 24-25 promise God's keeping. 1 Peter 1:3-5 says we are guarded by God's power through faith. Ephesians 1:13-14 says we are sealed with the Spirit. Romans 8:28-30 gives the golden chain. John 6:37-40 and 17:11-12 speak of Jesus keeping those the Father gave him. Hebrews 3:12-14, 6:4-12, and 10:26-39 are warnings. John 15:1-8 speaks of abiding. Colossians 1:21-23 calls for continuing in the faith. 2 Peter 1:10 urges making our calling and election sure. Romans 8:16 speaks of the Spirit's witness. 2 Corinthians 13:5 urges self-examination.

STEP 6

Application

If you doubt your salvation, take your eyes off yourself and look at Christ. Read John 10:27-30 slowly and rest.

If you have grown careless, hear the warnings kindly and ask whether you are abiding in Christ daily.

Share 1 John 5:13 with a struggling friend and pray that they would know they have eternal life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus, the Good Shepherd, for keeping you.
- Thank him that nothing can separate you from his love.
- Ask him to strengthen your assurance.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 123

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 JOHN 1:9

DAY 861 · WEEK 123

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 John 1:9 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

1 JOHN 1:9

REST

Meditation

This verse is a gift for anyone who has failed. The condition is simple: confess. To confess means to say the same thing about our sin that God says, not minimizing, excusing, or blaming. We do not have to clean ourselves up first.

The promise is two-sided. God is faithful: he keeps his covenant promises. And he is just: the penalty has been paid by Christ, so God does not forgive by ignoring justice but by satisfying it. Therefore the forgiveness is certain.

The result has two parts: forgiveness of our sins (the guilt is removed) and cleansing from unrighteousness (the stain and power of sin are dealt with). We are not left in the pit.

When shame tells you to hide, say this verse to God, and then name the specific sin. Accept his forgiveness, and walk in the light.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read Psalms 118 and 31, all of 1 John, and a pause on perseverance. Psalm 118 told us to give thanks to the LORD, whose steadfast love endures forever, and to take refuge in him rather than in man. Psalm 31 gave the prayer of committing our spirit into God's hand. First John 1 and 2 taught us that God is light, that confession brings forgiveness, that Christ is our advocate and propitiation, and that we must not love the world. First John 3 marveled at the love of the Father who calls us his children, and defined love as laying down our lives in deed and truth. First John 4 and 5 taught us to test the spirits, that God is love, that perfect love casts out fear, and that we can know that we have eternal life. Day 860 was a pause on perseverance and assurance: God keeps his people, and he wants us to know it.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

John gives several tests of genuine faith: believing that Jesus came in the flesh, obeying God's commands, and loving one another. Which of these tests encourages you most, and which do you want to grow in?

John says Jesus Christ the righteous is our advocate with the Father and the propitiation for our sins. How does knowing that Christ pleads for you change the way you respond when you sin?

John writes that he wants you to know you have eternal life. What gives you confidence about your salvation, and what makes you doubt? What promise of Scripture can you hold on to this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess your sins to God, naming them without excuse.

Thank him that he is faithful and just to forgive and cleanse.

Rest in his forgiveness.

DAY 862 · WEEK 124

2 John 1:1-13

Truth and love; the deceivers

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 John, a single chapter. It is the shortest book in the Bible by Greek word count and takes about two minutes to read. Notice how truth and love are joined, and how hospitality has limits when false teaching is at stake.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Second John is a personal letter from "the elder" (the apostle John, in his old age) to "the elect lady and her children," either a local congregation or a Christian woman and her family. The occasion was the same as in 1 John: itinerant teachers who denied that Jesus had come in the flesh were traveling from church to church. In the ancient world, traveling teachers depended on hospitality, and a believer's home could become a base for false teaching. John writes to praise faithfulness and to give a warning.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The elect lady and her children, whom I love in truth" (v. 1).
2. "I rejoiced greatly to find some of your children walking in the truth" (v. 4).
3. "And this is love, that we walk according to his commandments" (v. 6).
4. "For many deceivers have gone out into the world, those who do not confess the coming of Jesus Christ in the flesh" (v. 7).
5. "Watch yourselves, so that you may not lose what we have worked for, but may win a full reward" (v. 8).
6. "Whoever abides in the teaching has both the Father and the Son" (v. 9).
7. "Do not receive him into your house or give him any greeting" (v. 10).

8 “So that our joy may be complete” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John greets the church with love “in truth” and with the grace of “truth and love.” The words “truth” and “love” occur together throughout the letter, and both are essential. Truth without love is hard, and love without truth is sentimental. John says that the truth “abides in us and will be with us forever.” He rejoices that some of the children are walking in the truth, just as the Father commanded.

His request is the old commandment: “that we love one another. And this is love, that we walk according to his commandments.” Love is not just a feeling; it is obedience. This is the same message as in 1 John 5:3.

Then the warning: “For many deceivers have gone out into the world, those who do not confess the coming of Jesus Christ in the flesh. Such a one is the deceiver and the antichrist.” The false teachers were denying the incarnation. John tells the readers to watch themselves, so as not to lose the fruit of their labors but to receive a full reward. He draws the line sharply: “Everyone who goes on ahead and does not abide in the teaching of Christ, does not have God. Whoever abides in the teaching has both the Father and the Son.” Those who “go on ahead” claim to advance beyond the apostles’ teaching, but in fact they leave Christ behind.

The practical instruction is: “If anyone comes to you and does not bring this teaching, do not receive him into your house or give him any greeting, for whoever greets him takes part in his wicked works.” How do we apply this? It does not forbid showing kindness to unbelievers or neighbors, and it does not tell us to be rude to those who disagree on secondary matters. It concerns teachers who deny the core of the gospel, particularly the person and work of Christ, and who come as representatives of Christian faith. To welcome and fund such a teacher would be to support his work. Each situation calls for wisdom. We should hold firmly to the truth, and we should treat the people we disagree with with the patience Christ showed.

The letter ends as it began, with warm personal greetings: John hopes to visit and speak face to face, “so that our joy may be complete.” The children of your elect sister greet you. Nothing replaces the presence of Christians together.

STEP 5

Connection

1 John 2:18-27 and 4:1-6 give the same warning. 1 John 5:3 ties love to obedience. John 14:15 and 15:10 are Jesus' words on keeping his commandments. Galatians 1:6-9 pronounces a curse on a different gospel. Titus 3:10-11 instructs us to avoid a divisive person after warnings. Romans 16:17-18 also tells us to watch out for those who cause divisions. Romans 12:13 and Hebrews 13:2 commend hospitality. Matthew 5:43-48 teaches love for enemies. Ephesians 4:15 speaks of speaking the truth in love.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize verse 6: love is walking according to God's commandments.

Ask whether you tend to emphasize truth or love, and which you may be neglecting. Take one step to bring them together.

Test what you hear and read about Jesus by the apostolic teaching. If something denies Christ's deity or humanity, be cautious.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for truth and love in Jesus.
- Ask him to help you walk in the truth and love by obeying.
- Ask him to keep you from deceivers.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades."

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 863 · WEEK 124

3 John 1:1-14

Hospitality; Gaius and Diotrephes

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 3 John, a single chapter. It is a private letter to a friend named Gaius, with a contrast between two men in the church: Gaius, who welcomed missionaries, and Diotrephes, who refused them. Notice how generosity and pride show themselves in practice.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Third John is the companion to 2 John. In 2 John, John warns against receiving false teachers. In 3 John, he commends receiving true ones. Traveling missionaries went out "for the sake of the name," relying on the hospitality of local believers rather than taking support from pagans. Gaius had welcomed them, and a leader named Diotrephes had not. The letter gives a window into the ordinary life of a first-century church with its generosity, ambition, and conflict.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Beloved, I pray that all may go well with you and that you may be in good health, as it goes well with your soul" (v. 2).
2. "I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are walking in the truth" (v. 4).
3. "Beloved, it is a faithful thing you do in all your efforts for these brothers, strangers as they are" (v. 5).
4. "For they have gone out for the sake of the name, accepting nothing from the Gentiles" (v. 7).
5. "Therefore we ought to support people like these, that we may be fellow workers for the truth" (v. 8).

6. “Diotrephes, who likes to put himself first” (v. 9).
7. “Beloved, do not imitate evil but imitate good” (v. 11).
8. “Demetrius has received a good testimony from everyone” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

John writes to “the beloved Gaius, whom I love in truth.” His first words are a prayer for health: “I pray that all may go well with you and that you may be in good health, as it goes well with your soul.” It is a common greeting that implies that Gaius’s soul was doing well. It is not a promise that all believers will be healthy and wealthy but a loving wish for a friend. John rejoices when brothers testify to Gaius’s truth. “I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are walking in the truth.” For a spiritual father, there is no greater joy.

Gaius is praised for his hospitality: “it is a faithful thing you do in all your efforts for these brothers, strangers as they are.” They have testified to his love before the church. John urges him to send them on their journey “in a manner worthy of God.” Why? “For they have gone out for the sake of the name, accepting nothing from the Gentiles. Therefore we ought to support people like these, that we may be fellow workers for the truth.” When we support missionaries, teachers, and church planters, we share in their work. This is a strong argument for generosity in giving and hospitality.

By contrast, Diotrephes “likes to put himself first.” He does not acknowledge John’s authority. He is “talking wicked nonsense against us,” will not welcome the brothers, and even stops those who want to, putting them out of the church. We should not be surprised that even the early church had its power struggles. Pride is the opposite of the servant spirit of Christ. John plans to deal with him personally when he comes.

John then gives a principle: “Beloved, do not imitate evil but imitate good. Whoever does good is from God; whoever does evil has not seen God.” Our conduct reveals our relationship with God. Demetrius, probably the one who carried the letter, is commended as a model. He has a good testimony from everyone and from the truth itself.

The letter closes with the hope of seeing Gaius face to face: “Peace be to you. The friends greet you. Greet the friends, each by name.” Christian friendship is personal, valuing each by name. This tiny letter reminds us that the work of the gospel depends on ordinary acts of generosity as well as on great teachers.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 12:13, 1 Peter 4:9, and Hebrews 13:2 command hospitality. Matthew 10:9-14 describes how Jesus sent out his disciples to rely on hospitality. Philippians 4:14-18 commends partnership in giving. Titus 3:13 also speaks of sending teachers on their way. Mark 9:33-35 and 10:42-45 teach that greatness is service. 1 Peter 5:3 warns elders against domineering. Matthew 23:5-12 warns against love of honor. Luke 22:24-27 shows the disciples' own ambition. Philippians 2:3-4 calls us to humility.

STEP 6

Application

Is there a missionary, church planter, or a visiting speaker you could support with prayer, money, or hospitality? Do it this week.

Ask whether you ever "like to put yourself first" in your family, church, or workplace. Confess it and take a lower seat.

Write a note to someone who has been a Gaius to you, and thank them by name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for friends who walk in the truth.

Ask him to make you generous to those who serve him.

Ask him to keep you from loving to be first.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades."

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 864 · WEEK 124

Jude 1:1-25

Contend for the faith once delivered

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jude, a single chapter. Jude writes with urgency about false teachers who have crept into the church, and ends with one of the most beautiful doxologies in the Bible. Notice the examples from history and the practical instructions in verses 20 to 23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jude, the brother of James and therefore a brother of Jesus (though he calls himself a servant), intended to write about "our common salvation" but found it necessary instead to write a call to defend the faith. People had slipped into the churches who denied Christ's lordship and turned grace into an excuse for immorality. Jude's letter is closely parallel to 2 Peter 2. It uses examples from the Old Testament and from Jewish writings of the period.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Contend for the faith that was once for all delivered to the saints" (v. 3).
2. "Pervert the grace of our God into sensuality" (v. 4).
3. "He did not presume to pronounce a blasphemous judgment" (v. 9).
4. "Building yourselves up in your most holy faith; praying in the Holy Spirit" (v. 20).
5. "Keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ that leads to eternal life" (v. 21).
6. "And have mercy on those who doubt" (v. 22).
7. "Save others by snatching them out of the fire" (v. 23).
8. "Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you blameless before the presence of his glory with great joy" (v. 24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jude introduces himself and greets his readers as "those who are called, beloved in God the Father and kept for Jesus Christ." Called, loved, kept: three words that summarize the Christian's security. Then the appeal: "Contend for the faith that was once for all delivered to the saints." The faith is a body of truth, entrusted to the apostles, complete and unchanging. We do not invent it or improve on it, but we guard and defend it. "Contend" is a strong word, like an athlete struggling for a prize, though Paul says the servant of the Lord must not be quarrelsome (2 Timothy 2:24). The way to contend is with truth, courage, and compassion.

The danger: "certain people have crept in unnoticed who long ago were designated for this condemnation, ungodly people, who pervert the grace of our God into sensuality and deny our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ." Their error is two-fold: moral (grace as license) and doctrinal (denying Christ's lordship). Jude gives three examples of judgment: Israel, who was saved out of Egypt but destroyed when they did not believe; the angels who left their proper place; and Sodom and Gomorrah. Great privilege does not protect those who persist in unbelief.

The false teachers "reject authority and blaspheme the glorious ones." Jude contrasts them with the archangel Michael, who, even in a dispute with the devil, "did not presume to pronounce a blasphemous judgment, but said, The Lord rebuke you." Jude refers to a tradition about Michael and Moses' body, probably from a Jewish writing of the time, and to a prophecy of Enoch, which seems to come from the Book of 1 Enoch. Does that make these books Scripture? No. Paul also quoted pagan poets (Acts 17:28) without making them canonical. An inspired author may cite a true statement from a non-inspired source. This is why the canon (see Day 851) is important.

Jude's descriptions of the false teachers are some of the most vivid in the Bible: "hidden reefs" at the love feasts, "waterless clouds, swept along by winds," "fruitless trees in autumn, twice dead, uprooted," "wild waves of the sea, casting up the foam of their own shame," "wandering stars for whom the gloom of utter darkness has been reserved forever." Their end is judgment, as Enoch prophesied. They are grumblers, malcontents, following their own sinful desires, loud-mouthed boasters, showing favoritism for gain.

Then Jude turns to the readers: "But you, beloved, remember the predictions of the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ." Scoffers will come. Our response is a fourfold program: "building yourselves up in your most holy faith; praying in the Holy Spirit, keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ that leads to eternal life." Notice the Trinity: Spirit, God, Lord Jesus. Faith, prayer, love, and hope together keep us in God's love. And then ministry to others: "And have mercy on those who doubt; save others by snatching

them out of the fire; to others show mercy with fear, hating even the garment stained by the flesh." Three types of people receive three types of care: gentleness for the doubting, urgency for the endangered, and cautious compassion for those entangled in sin.

The letter ends with a doxology that has been read at countless services: "Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you blameless before the presence of his glory with great joy, to the only God, our Savior, through Jesus Christ our Lord, be glory, majesty, dominion, and authority, before all time and now and forever. Amen." We contend for the faith, but ultimately it is God who keeps us. And he will present us blameless, with great joy.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Peter 2 is a close parallel. Numbers 14 and 26:64-65 record the wilderness generation. Genesis 6:1-4 and 19:1-29 relate to the angels and Sodom. Zechariah 3:2 contains the words "The Lord rebuke you." Genesis 5:18-24 mentions Enoch. Numbers 16 and 22-24 tell of Korah and Balaam. Genesis 4:3-8 tells of Cain. 1 Timothy 6:20 and 2 Timothy 1:13-14 call us to guard the deposit. Acts 20:28-31 warns of wolves. Romans 16:25-27 is another great doxology. Philippians 1:6 and 1 Thessalonians 5:23-24 offer similar assurance.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize verse 24, and say it at the end of the day as a prayer of trust.

Choose one of the four disciplines in verses 20 and 21 (faith, prayer, love, hope) and strengthen it this week.

Think of a person who doubts. Reach out to them with patience and mercy.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are called, loved, and kept.

Ask him to help you contend for the faith with truth and love.

Ask him to keep you in his love and show mercy to the doubting.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

“Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades.”

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 865 · WEEK 124

Review and Reflection

Unit 24 review, Faith Lived Out, General Epistles

Year 2 · Unit 24 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "We love because he first loved us."
>
> 1 JOHN 4:19

REST

Meditation

This short verse is the heart of the General Epistles. James told us that faith without works is dead, Peter told us to love one another earnestly, John told us that God is love, and Jude told us to keep ourselves in the love of God. Where does that love begin? Not in us. "We love because he first loved us."

The love of God came first, in the cross: "In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins." Our love for God and for each other is the echo of his. We are not trying to earn love; we are responding to a love already given.

This is freeing. On days when we feel unloving, we do not manufacture love by willpower. We look again at the love that came first, and let it fill us and overflow. Say this verse slowly, and thank him for loving you first.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit took us through the General Epistles, which ask what genuine faith looks like in real life. James taught that faith is tested by trials and shown by works: we are to be doers of the word, tame the tongue by God's grace, show no partiality, and pray with patience. Psalms 12, 15, and 24 deepened this with the purity of the LORD's words, the character of those who dwell with God, and the King of glory who alone has clean hands and a pure heart. We paused to consider saving faith: knowing, agreeing, trusting, and how faith alone is never alone. First Peter gave us a living hope, our identity as a chosen race, royal priesthood, and

holy nation, the example of Christ's suffering, and the call to cast our anxieties on God while resisting the roaring lion. Second Peter reminded us that God has given us everything for life and godliness, that Scripture is breathed out by the Spirit, and that the Lord's delay is patience. We paused on the canon: why we have sixty-six books. Psalms 34, 118, and 31 invited us to taste and see, to give thanks for steadfast love, and to commit our spirit to God's hand. First John gave tests of genuine faith: walking in the light, confessing sin, loving the brothers, believing in the incarnate Son, and knowing that we have eternal life. We paused on perseverance and assurance. Second John and Third John showed truth and love in hospitality, and Jude called us to contend for the faith once delivered and trust the God who is able to keep us from stumbling.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does James reconcile "faith without works is dead" with justification by faith alone?

In your own words, explain how Paul and James fit together, and give one example of faith showing itself in works.

What does Peter mean by "a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation"?

Write what these titles tell you about who you are as a Christian, and how they shape how you live as an exile.

What are the tests of genuine faith in 1 John?

List the tests John gives, and choose one you want to grow in this month.

What does Jude mean when he says to "contend for the faith"?

Describe what it looks like to contend for the faith with both truth and mercy, using verses 20 to 23.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for loving you first.

Thank him for what the General Epistles have taught you about living the faith.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.